

25, Nomadic Regimes and Feudalization, and Why the Xiongnu Were Disproportionately Formidable

Next, let us consider nomadic regimes. The focus here is not on regimes established by nomadic peoples who conquered agricultural production zones, but rather on regimes where nomadism constitutes the primary **production mode** (生产方式).

It is glaringly evident that it is virtually impossible for a purely nomadic regime to organically develop a **feudal system** (封建体制), let alone a mature one analogous to Western Europe.

First, the feudal system is intrinsically predicated upon the control and occupation of land; land constitutes the **primary factor of production** (首位生产要素) and the absolute bedrock of the social power structure. For nomadic peoples, land functions primarily as a spatial locus for grazing livestock rather than a fixed means of production. Their primary concern is the ecological fluctuation of pastures, not concrete property rights over the land.

Second, nomadic production strictly relies on seasonal pastures. Even in the short term, the population exists in a state of perpetual migration; over the long term, demographic mobility becomes even more pronounced. This extreme hyper-mobility renders the establishment of a fixed land ownership system and a labyrinthine social hierarchy phenomenally difficult.

Third, the foundational cornerstone enabling the initial formation of a feudal system is a self-sufficient **natural economy** (自然经济), with the **manor** (庄园) functioning as the basic economic unit, and where peasants are bound to the land with severely restricted personal freedom. A purely nomadic mode of production is fundamentally incapable of achieving genuine self-sufficiency. Meat and dairy cannot possibly fulfill all human nutritional requirements. Therefore, all regimes predicated primarily on nomadic production are structurally compelled to engage in frequent material exchanges with surrounding regimes—especially agricultural states—whether through violent or non-violent means.

Finally, the nomadic mode of production fundamentally struggles to establish a stable taxation apparatus, nor does it possess the capacity to provide substantive public services. At best, a nomadic ruler periodically extracts tribute from subordinate tribal chieftains and provides military protection in return. The inability to institutionalize a stable taxation system constitutes a terminal structural deficiency when attempting to organize a complex state. To overcome this, formidable nomadic rulers frequently resort to distributing the spoils of conquest wars to organize the state apparatus, but this is patently unsustainable. Once the regime suffers a catastrophic defeat, it is highly liable to disintegrate instantly. Conversely, if it secures enough victories, it is inevitably forced to mutate into a regime presiding over an overwhelmingly sedentary, agriculturally productive population.

To forcefully **feudalize** a nomadic society, one must irrevocably thrust it into a colossal market mechanism. This market must be capable of efficiently converting the **social surplus** (社会剩余) generated by pastoral production into currency and other commodities. Furthermore, it necessitates a formidable (external) power to rationally allocate and strictly demarcate pastures, thereby artificially maintaining a rigid social hierarchy.

If we examine the Mongolian region during the terminal phase of the Chinese imperial era, this exact mutation did, to a certain extent, occur.

First, during the Wanli era of the Ming Dynasty, Altan Khan (俺答汗) negotiated a peace treaty with the Ming imperial government, terminating two centuries of protracted hostility between the Ming and the Mongols. With the formal opening of border markets (*though the smuggling of alcohol had never ceased*), the Mongolian region was instantaneously integrated into a massive market network. Concurrently, the Mongols' second historical encounter with Tibet facilitated their mass conversion to Tibetan Buddhism, which at the time was already evolving into a **feudalized religion** (封建化宗教).

Subsequently, the rising Qing Dynasty utilized a combination of military coercion and marital alliances to subsume both Inner and Outer Mongolia under its dominion, implementing the League and Banner system (盟旗制度). The term **Jasagh** (扎萨克 / Zasak) became the specific designation for hereditary **feudal lords** in the (Outer) Mongolian region during the Qing era. All mountains, rivers, forests, and fields within their fiefdoms were their absolute private property, and they bore zero corvée or tax obligations to the Qing central government. The *Jasagh* governed the populace within their fiefdoms, compelling them to pay taxes and perform corvée labor. The bonds of personal dependence (人身依附关系) were exceptionally rigid.

It must be recognized that the Qing Dynasty's ability to metamorphose Mongolia into a region dominated by a feudal system relied entirely upon two pillars: first, the Qing possessed an overwhelming military supremacy that ensured its policies could be coercively implemented; second, the Qing Dynasty itself had already been drawn into the vortex of the global market. The empire accumulated monumental trade surpluses through the treaty ports along its southeastern coast. The global trade network entered China through these nodes, traversed domestic commercial routes up to the Great Wall, and from there, Shanxi merchants (晋商) ventured north, crossing the entirety of Mongolia to reach Maimai-cheng (买卖城 / Kyakhta Trade City). This renowned border trade hub was situated on Qing territory south of the Kyakhta River, while the city of Kyakhta north of the river belonged to the Russian Empire. During the Sino-Russian trade of the 18th and early 19th centuries, the Qing identically secured massive trade surpluses.

It was precisely under the conditions of this profound integration into the international market that the feudalized (Outer) Mongolian region managed to establish a stable taxation system. The *Regulations of the Lifanyuan* (《理藩院则例》), codified in the early years of the Shunzhi reign, stipulated highly diversified tax extraction methods for the *Jasagh* fiefdoms: those with many sheep paid directly in sheep; those with few sheep paid in rice; those with an exceptional abundance of sheep were additionally required to pay in carpets; and those possessing dairy cows had to provide butter and kumiss (乳油和乳酒).

However, the nomadic mode of production is fundamentally distinct from agriculture. The in-kind taxes paid in agricultural regions are merely grain seeds, requiring only physical storage space. Yet, under the nomadic production mode, once live livestock are surrendered as tax, one must immediately calculate whether the lord's directly administered lands possess the ecological carrying capacity to sustain that many cattle and sheep. After all, livestock require sustained consumption of grass and water. This biological reality inherently clashes with the rigid territorial boundaries demanded by a **feudal system**.

Consequently, by the late Qing Dynasty, the *Regulations of the Lifanyuan* completely abandoned the requirement to collect diverse physical goods. Regardless of the quantity of livestock a taxed household possessed, all dues were converted into rice based on a unified standard. Considering that

the Outer Mongolian region produced virtually zero rice, the ability to collect taxes standardized in rice serves as definitive proof of the staggering ubiquity of Han Chinese merchants operating within Mongolia.

Nevertheless, such a feudal system undeniably held absolutely zero organic meaning for a nomadic region. The colossal, hyper-active, and highly monetized market upon which it relied could only possibly materialize in the wake of the early modern Age of Discovery—which, chronologically speaking, was excessively late. Not to mention, it required the continuous enforcement of an external hegemon.

Furthermore, judging from the historical realities of Mongolia's development during the Qing Dynasty, the feudal system was catastrophically incompatible with nomadic regions. For instance, the draconian restrictions forbidding herdsman from crossing Banner borders to graze (越旗放牧)—was this not an explicit violation of the natural laws governing pastoralism? Over the more than two centuries of Qing rule in Mongolia, the entire region plunged into a catastrophic recession. The population plummeted, sexually transmitted diseases became rampant, and the aristocracy was universally mired in insurmountable debt. Even acknowledging that the initial stages of **feudalization** (封建化) genuinely tend to exhibit certain symptoms of decline, the catastrophic events that transpired in Qing-era Mongolia were blatantly pathological.

This tragic reality constitutes one of the historical reasons why Mongolia has harbored a prolonged estrangement from China and generated enduring anti-Chinese sentiments.

Similarly, logically speaking, it should be impossible for a nomadic region to experience a genuine **classical period** (古典时期). The nomadic mode of production fundamentally struggles to effectively ameliorate the natural environment, and historically, the population carrying capacity of nomadic regions stagnated at a consistent level for prolonged periods. The impact of technological advancement was far inferior to even minor climatic shifts.

However, we indeed observe a highly anomalous phenomenon here: the **Xiongnu Empire** (匈奴帝国). As the first nomadic empire to unify the Mongolian Plateau and its peripheries, the military manpower and political cohesion it could mobilize were disproportionately formidable.

What is most perplexing is that the Xiongnu regime genuinely exhibited certain "classical characteristics." For instance, among the various nomadic peoples migrating back and forth across northern China, the Xiongnu were exceptionally proficient in constructing walled settlements (筑城). Thus far, archaeological excavations have unearthed nearly thirty Xiongnu settlements, stretching from south of Lake Baikal down into Inner Mongolia. From the fall of the Xiongnu right up to the rise of the Mongols, no other nomadic regime is known to have constructed such a multitude of walled settlements in the northern Chinese pastoral regions. It is highly probable that even the unified Mongolian Empire under Genghis Khan could not compare in this specific regard.

The Xiongnu also utilized precious metals like gold far more extensively than subsequent nomadic peoples. Of course, a stark difference remains between this and a genuine classical empire: in **classical empires**, precious metals circulated as functional currency, whereas expecting such a highly developed monetary economy in a nomadic region 2,200 years ago is unrealistic. The Xiongnu generally utilized gold as funerary objects (陪葬品) for the high aristocracy.

The armaments of this nomadic regime were equally sophisticated. Unearthed weapons are predominantly composed of bronze and iron (*though one cannot exclude the possibility that non-metallic weapons simply failed to preserve*), and Xiongnu brick-and-tile kilns (砖瓦窑址) and iron-smelting sites have also been discovered. Judging from the historical records of the Han Dynasty, the Han clearly recognized the terrifying martial prowess of the Xiongnu as an adversary, asserting that the Xiongnu soldiers were "entirely armored cavalry" (尽为甲骑 / primarily utilizing leather armor) and were exceptionally skilled in equestrian combat.

The relative economic independence of the Xiongnu regime is equally a highly bizarre phenomenon. As previously mentioned, it is structurally impossible for a purely nomadic mode of production to achieve self-sufficiency; nomadic inhabitants are compelled to engage in commodity exchange with the outside world to sustain their survival. Yet, it is widely known that both the *Records of the Grand Historian* (《史记》) and the *Book of Han* (《汉书》) explicitly record the following historical event. Zhonghang Yue (中行说), a Han defector who sought refuge with the Xiongnu, observed that the Laoshang Chanyu (老上单于) was overly fond of the silk and food sent by the Han Dynasty through the *Heqin* (和亲 / peace-making marriage) policy.

Zhonghang Yue consequently advised the Chanyu, arguing that the fundamental reason the Xiongnu maintained military superiority over the Han was precisely because their customs regarding food and clothing differed from the Han people, and that they "did not rely upon the Han" (无仰于汉). He warned that if the Xiongnu altered their indigenous customs, the Han could effortlessly bribe and subvert the Xiongnu populace. He advised the Chanyu to discard the gifts sent by the Han to demonstrate the superiority of the Xiongnu's own way of life. Consequently, the Laoshang Chanyu came to value Zhonghang Yue even more profoundly.

Although border trade (边市贸易) between the Han and Xiongnu persistently existed to some degree—in fact, the famous Mayi Trap (马邑之谋) utilized a major border trade hub as bait—the fact that Zhonghang Yue possessed the confidence to articulate the phrase "do not rely upon the Han" strongly implies that the Xiongnu's development in industries beyond mere pastoralism had likely become quite substantial.

Furthermore, even though the *Records of the Grand Historian* and the *Book of Han* merely provide abbreviated accounts of the Xiongnu's bureaucratic apparatus, it is not difficult to discern that such a hierarchical system was phenomenally overly complex for a 2nd-century BC nomadic empire.

One particularly shocking aspect is that, although the political structure of the **Xiongnu Empire** remained fundamentally predicated on pasture allocation, it possessed a characteristic highly resembling the rotating bureaucratic appointment system (流官) that is exceptionally rare among nomadic peoples. Take, for example, the *Tuqi* King of the Left (左贤王 / Wise King of the Left), which was the highest aristocratic title and simultaneously the official position governing the vast eastern territories of the Xiongnu (匈奴左地). The appointment of the *Tuqi* King of the Left was manipulated almost entirely by the reigning Chanyu; the Chanyu could even arbitrarily alter the very title of the "Tuqi King of the Left."

Generally, the *Tuqi* King of the Left was held by the Crown Prince. However, on the one hand, the Chanyu possessed the absolute despotic power to change the heir apparent or execute the first-in-line successor to the *Tuqi* King of the Left. On the other hand, if a newly ascended Chanyu had not previously served as the *Tuqi* King of the Left, he could absolutely demote the sons of the former

Tuqi King of the Left and appoint his own brother or son to the position. It must be understood that the *Tuqi* King of the Left was an immensely powerful figure, even when viewed on a global scale at the time. At its absolute zenith, this position could mobilize seventy to eighty thousand cavalymen, and even after suffering repeated catastrophic defeats, it could still field thirty thousand combat-ready cavalry.

At least according to Chinese historical records, the Xiongnu royal house firmly grasped the administrative control and military command of various fiefdoms strictly through the centralized appointment of the high aristocracy. This is an astonishing reality for a nomadic people. Even after Genghis Khan unified Mongolia, the so-called **Ulus** (兀鲁思 / the Mongolian term for people and fiefdom) were inherited hereditarily by the ennobled princes. The Great Khan was fundamentally incapable of exercising the absolute despotic power to arbitrarily strip titles and fiefdoms in the manner the Chanyu once did.

In fact, it is easy to observe that this bureaucratic system of the **Xiongnu Empire** already bore a striking resemblance to early *classical empires*. For instance, the Maurya Dynasty in India adopted an identical system where princes were dispatched to govern provinces (*the Maurya Dynasty had very few provinces, currently estimated at roughly four to six*), and the governor of a crucial province might simultaneously hold the status of heir apparent.

If one evaluates this from the perspective of the Chinese Empire, one could naturally ridicule the primitiveness and crudeness of this bureaucratic system. However, for a regime whose primary mode of production was nomadism, achieving such a structure was genuinely unfathomable.

A particularly easily overlooked key point is that the Xiongnu were quite similar to the contemporaneous Han people in terms of religion, and the Xiongnu were highly adept at utilizing religion.

The religious center of the **Xiongnu Empire** was "Longcheng" (龙城). This was the location of the largest of the three routine annual gatherings held in the fifth month, where various tribes congregated to sacrifice to their ancestors, Heaven, Earth, and spirits. (*During the first month, tribal chieftains arrived at the Royal Court of the Chanyu [单于庭] for a minor gathering, perhaps involving the formulation of plans for the new year and winter relief issues. In autumn, when people and livestock multiplied, another large-scale gathering was held; they conducted sacrificial ceremonies surrounding forests and tallied the population and livestock numbers of the tribes*).

The isolated appearance of this event in the *Records of the Grand Historian* (《史记》) presents no issue, but looking across the entirety of ancient Chinese documentary records, it becomes completely incomprehensible. The Xiongnu Chanyu, as the supreme ruler of a nomadic empire, was actually capable of routinely convening his primary subordinates three times a year. The cohesive and convening role played by Longcheng as the religious center of the **Xiongnu Empire** did not reappear in any nomadic regime for over 1,300 years after the Xiongnu were defeated by the Han Dynasty, not until the Mongols constructed Karakorum.

And such routine, high-frequency activities bearing the nature of pilgrimages and confederate assemblies, which persisted for nearly a century, never reappeared after the Xiongnu. Even during the era when the Qing Dynasty comprehensively ruled Mongolia, the Inner *Jasagh* (内扎萨克) were only required to make a pilgrimage to the Qing's **Boghda Khan** (博格达汗) once every three years; the league assembly activities were initially held once a year, and were later relaxed even further.

Corresponding to this excessively formidable ruling power, the status bestowed upon the Chanyu himself within the social consciousness also possessed a certain divinity. He "*worshipped the sun in the morning and the moon in the evening*," (朝拜日, 夕拜月) claiming to be "established by Heaven." Recently unearthed Xiongnu eaves tiles (瓦当) in Mongolia are also inscribed with the four characters "Son of Heaven, Chanyu" (天子单于). This ideology was clearly highly consistent with the so-called "Son of Heaven" in the **Central Plains** (中原), and the Xiongnu specifically emphasized this point during diplomacy with the Han Dynasty to assert parity.

The Xiongnu placed great importance on tombs. Archaeological discoveries reveal an emphasis on lavish burials; the scale of the mausoleums was exceptionally large relative to a nomadic regime. The largest Xiongnu tomb excavated to date is almost exactly the same size as the Qin Duke No. 1 Tomb (秦公一号大墓). This attitude toward funerals and burials was also consistent with China at the time.

The Xiongnu, like the Han people, believed that spirits existed after death (*without distinguishing between friend or foe*) and could send down fortune or misfortune, necessitating the pacification of malevolent spirits. For example, after the Han general Li Guangli (李广利) was executed by the Xiongnu Chanyu, he was deemed a malevolent spirit due to a series of subsequent natural disasters; the Xiongnu felt fear and consequently offered sacrifices to Li Guangli's spirit to pacify it. A famous spirit officially sacrificed to by the Han Dynasty was named "Qin Zhong" (秦中); Qin Zhong was the Second Emperor of Qin, Huhai. This was identically to prevent the spirit from causing trouble.

The Xiongnu also engaged in agricultural production, and a large number of iron agricultural tools have even been unearthed, which exhibit no difference in shape and structure from those of the Han Dynasty. Naturally, judging from the iron-smelting sites, the Xiongnu's iron-smelting technology had already diverged from that of the **Central Plains** during the Qin and Han periods. However, this was highly likely caused by further developments in iron-smelting technology within the **Central Plains** following a polarization; after all, from the late Warring States period to the mid-Eastern Han Dynasty, China's iron-smelting technology indeed experienced explosive growth.

My contention is that a nomadic region itself naturally would not experience a classical empire stage. The reason the various incomprehensible characteristics of the Xiongnu emerged at that time was because the **Xiongnu Empire** itself was forged by the conspicuous spillover of the **Hua-Xia people's "Great Expansion"** (大扩张) process at the eastern end of the **Eurasian Steppe** (欧亚大草原).

Here, I will use an extensively recorded and highly typical example from our nation's documentary sources to illustrate this point: specifically, the event in the spring of the second year of the Yuanshou era (121 BC) when Huo Qubing (霍去病) launched his first major offensive into the Hexi Corridor and captured the Golden Man for Worshipping Heaven (祭天金人) from the Xiongnu's Xiutu tribe (休屠部). Here, as long as no glaring contradictions appear within the documentary records, we will provisionally assume them to be accurate.

Following the chronological order of appearance in the documents, the Xiongnu Golden Man for Worshipping Heaven first appears in the *Records of the Grand Historian: Account of the Xiongnu* (《史记·匈奴列传》), describing when Huo Qubing first breached the Hexi region and captured this object. Both the *Shiji Jijie* (《史记集解》) and the *Shiji Zhengyi* (《史记正义》) provided highly consistent annotations: namely, the location where the Xiongnu originally worshipped Heaven was

at the foot of Ganquan Mountain (甘泉山), northwest of Yunyang County (*present-day Chunhua County, Xianyang City, a straight-line distance of 100 kilometers from urban Xi'an*).

Later, the State of Qin captured this area (*judging from the process of Qin attacking and annihilating the Yiqu [义渠], it was perhaps occupied during the reign of King Huiwen of Qin*). Subsequently, the sacrificial location was relocated to the "Right Land of the Xiutu" (休屠右地) (*which should refer to the territory of the Xiutu tribe; the "right land" refers to the west from a north-to-south-facing perspective relative to the Royal Court of the Chanyu*). Therefore, the Xiutu King retained this Golden Man for Worshipping Heaven, and this golden man ought to symbolize the image of the Heavenly God.

However, here the *Shiji Suoyin* (《史记索隐》), quoting the *Shiji Yinyi* (《史记音义》), claims that the Xiongnu (*though, of course, they were not yet uniformly called Xiongnu at that time*) were already using the golden man when they worshipped Heaven at Ganquan Mountain. Yet, it expresses disagreement with this assertion, maintaining instead that the Han Dynasty only placed the golden man at Ganquan for sacrifice after having captured it.

Faced with the important sacrificial props and religious symbols of the Xiongnu (匈奴人), the Han people (汉朝人), despite being their mortal enemies, showed considerable enthusiasm and respect. The *Hanwu Gushi* (《汉武故事》), the most important unofficial history regarding Emperor Wu of Han (汉武帝), states: "*Having captured the Golden Man of the Heavenly Sacrifice, the Emperor considered it a great deity and arrayed it in the Ganquan Palace. The man was generally over a zhang tall; they did not offer sacrifices or prayers, but only burned incense and worshipped. The Heavenly Sacrifice was eight chi long, holding up the sun and moon, and was sacrificed to with cattle. The Emperor ordered it to be worshipped according to its local customs. The fangshi all believed it was a barbarian deity, unsuitable to be in the center, and so it was stopped.*" (‘‘获天祭金人，上以为大神，列于甘泉宫。人率长丈余，不祭祀，但烧香礼拜。天祭长八尺，擎日月，祭以牛。上令依其方俗礼之，方士皆以为夷狄鬼神，不宜在中，因乃止。’’)

There are many extra details here, indicating that the "Golden Man for Worshipping Heaven" (祭天金人) was not a single object. The "Golden Man" (金人) was a metal human statue approximately two and a half meters tall, while the "Heavenly Sacrifice" (天祭) was an unknown object about two meters long. Judging from the method of sacrifice, the Golden Man (金人) was clearly more essential; from the size comparison and the function of the "Heavenly Sacrifice" (天祭) holding up the sun and moon, the "Heavenly Sacrifice" appeared to be a tool used by the Heavenly God—to represented by the Golden Man—to maintain the operation of the world.

Later, Wei Shou (魏收) provided a similar account in the *Wei Shu: Treatise on Buddhism and Daoism* (《魏书 释老志》) (likely derived from the *Hanwu Gushi* [《汉武故事》]), but claimed that the Golden Man (金人) here was a Buddhist statue and omitted the content regarding the "Heavenly Sacrifice" (天祭). This selection clearly had a purpose. In 121 BC, Buddhist statue art was only just beginning to develop, let alone the possibility of cast-metal Buddhist statues appearing in the hands of the Xiongnu (匈奴人). To make people believe the Golden Man (金人) was genuinely a Buddhist statue, Wei Shou (魏收) had to remove the unidentifiable "Heavenly Sacrifice" (天祭), otherwise people would immediately know it was not a Buddhist statue.

Interestingly, although the Xiutu King (休屠王) and the Hunxie King (浑邪王) agreed to surrender to the Han Dynasty but the former was killed by the latter midway, the Xiutu King's eldest son, Jin Midi (金日磾), was later highly regarded by Emperor Wu of Han (汉武帝). He was continuously promoted to Imperial Household Grandee (光禄大夫) and designated as Huo Guang's (霍光) deputy to assist the young Emperor Zhao of Han, Liu Fuling (汉昭帝刘弗陵). In the final "Appraisal" (赞曰) section of the *Book of Han: Biographies of Huo Guang and Jin Midi* (《汉书 霍光金日磾传》), the author Ban Gu (班固) wrote: "*Originally, because the Xiutu made the Golden Man as the lord of heavenly sacrifice, he was thus bestowed the surname Jin [Gold].*" (“本以休屠作金人为祭天主，故因赐姓金氏云。”)

This record is very crucial. It not only mentions why Jin Midi (金日磾) was bestowed the surname Jin, but also explicitly points out that the Xiongnu Xiutu tribe (匈奴休屠部) possessed the capability to manufacture golden men (金人). That Jin Midi (金日磾) himself could be highly regarded by Emperor Wu of Han (汉武帝) naturally involved his loyalty and competence. However, for a foreign prince to achieve the status of a regent minister entrusted with an orphaned emperor (托孤大臣), we cannot rule out that this was related to his background as the Xiutu prince.

Of course, astute readers will also clearly notice the act of sacrificing cattle to the "Heavenly Sacrifice" (天祭). Looking at our nation's history, the practice of killing both cattle and horses during sacrifices simultaneously existed for both the sedentary peoples of the **Central Plains** (中原民族) and the northern nomadic peoples (北方游牧民族). But relatively speaking, horses were more important to nomadic peoples, while killing cattle was more common for the people of the **Central Plains**, and over time, the **Central Plains** regions placed less and less emphasis on killing horses. This perhaps already hints at the origins of the Xiutu tribe (休屠部). However, because we do not know whether Emperor Wu of Han (汉武帝) worshipped exactly according to the Xiongnu's original sacrificial methods or substituted his own, and considering the *Hanwu Gushi* (《汉武故事》) is not an official history (正史) after all, we will not discuss it further.

What is more bizarre is that the Xiutu King (休屠王), as a Xiongnu grand chieftain who reneged midway while surrendering to the Han and was killed, actually enjoyed sacrifices throughout the Han Dynasty. The *Book of Han* (《汉书》) records this information in two separate places: first in the *Treatise on Sacrifices, Part II* (《郊祀志下》), and second in the *Treatise on Geography, Part I* (《地理志上》). The *Treatise on Sacrifices, Part II* (《郊祀志下》), when writing about important sacrificial sites in counties near the capital during Emperor Xuan of Han's (汉宣帝) reign, states: "In Yunyang, there is the Shrine of the Jinglu Spirit, where the Xiutu King is sacrificed to" (“云阳有径路神祠，祭休屠王也”). This indicates that sacrificial activities existed there at the time. Yan Shigu (颜师古) annotated that this Jinglu Spirit (径路神) was originally a god worshipped by the Xiongnu.

The *Treatise on Geography, Part I* (《地理志上》), when writing about the Zuofengyi (左冯翊) region, finally mentioned Yunyang County (云阳县), stating it "*has three shrines: the Xiutu, the Golden Man, and the Jinglu Spirit, and three shrines for Yue shamans: [character], [character].*" (“有休屠、金人及径路神祠三所，越巫〈卯古〉〈襄阨〉祠三所。”). Ignoring those three shrines of the southern Yue people (南方越人), Wang Xianqian (王先谦) (the author of the *Supplementary Annotations to the Book of Han* [《汉书补注》]) annotated here that the so-called "Jinglu" (径路) was the name of the Xiutu King (休屠王), who became a god after death; the Xiongnu worshipped

him in the past, and now the Han Dynasty continued it. It was not a sacrifice to a precious sword called the "Jinglu sword" (径路刀), which earned its name because it was left behind by the Jinglu Spirit (径路神).

If we now search for this "Jinglu sword" (径路刀), we find it appears in a very important place. The *Book of Han: Account of the Xiongnu, Part II* (《汉书 匈奴传下》) records that during the reign of Emperor Yuan of Han (汉元帝), Han officials Han Chang (韩昌) and Zhang Meng (张猛) established an alliance with the Huhanye Chanyu (呼韩邪单于): "*Chang, Meng, the Chanyu, and the ministers all ascended the East Mountain of the Nuo River in Xiongnu territory, sacrificed a white horse, the Chanyu used the Jinglu sword and a gold spoon to stir the wine, and using the skull of the Yuezhi King, whom the Laoshang Chanyu had defeated, as a drinking vessel, they collectively drank the blood oath.*" (昌、猛与单于及大臣俱登匈奴诺水东山，刑白马，单于以径路刀金留犁挠酒，以老上单于所破月氏王头为饮器者共饮血盟”).

Here, to demonstrate his high regard for the alliance with the Han Dynasty, the Chanyu brought out an ancestral treasure of the Xiongnu royal family. He used the Jinglu sword (径路刀) to carve words onto a rice spoon (饭匕) (presumably swearing never to betray the alliance), stirred the rice spoon in the wine vessel, and then poured the wine into the wine bowl made from the Yuezhi King's (月氏王) skull and drank it (according to Yan Shigu [颜师古] quoting Ying Shao [应劭] of the Eastern Han).

Although such a bizarre ritual might seem quite ridiculous to people today, at the time, it was indeed the highest courtesy the Chanyu could offer. The Han Dynasty's reaction to this was very interesting. After hearing about this, Han officials unanimously agreed: "Forming an alliance is acceptable, but the curse is too severe, and the alliance ritual is too solemn, leaving the Han Dynasty with absolutely no room to maneuver. We should sacrifice to Heaven again to dissolve this alliance, and punish the two envoys." (结盟可以，但是赌咒太狠，结盟的仪式太过郑重，汉朝毫无回应的余地。应当再次祭告上天解除这个盟约，并且惩罚两个使者”). At that time, the Han Dynasty absolutely no longer considered the Xiongnu a peer adversary capable of standing on equal footing, and did not wish to establish an alliance oath with them that was too severely worded.

Another thought-provoking matter is the surrender of the Hunxie King (浑邪王) and the Xiutu King (休屠王) in the autumn of the second year of the Yuanshou era (元狩二年秋天), following Huo Qubing's (霍去病) two major devastating strikes against the Xiongnu (匈奴人) in the Hexi region (河西地区). Regarding this event, the five accounts in the official histories (正史) are not consistent.

The *Records of the Grand Historian: Account of the Xiongnu* (《史记 匈奴列传》) indicates that the Chanyu (单于), furious that the two kings, Hunxie and Xiutu, were severely defeated by the Han army (汉军) twice within half a year, wanted to recall and kill them. It did not specify who was to be killed; from the semantics, it should imply killing both kings. These two Xiongnu kings felt fear and plotted to surrender to the Han Dynasty (汉朝); Huo Qubing went to receive them. The Hunxie King killed the Xiutu King, annexed the latter's tribesmen, and then surrendered to the Han Dynasty, but it did not explain the reason for the killing.

The *Biographies of the General of Chariots and Cavalry and the General of Agile Cavalry* (《卫将军骠骑列传》) specifies that the Chanyu wanted to kill the Hunxie King and had no intention of killing the Xiutu King. It completely omits any record of the Xiutu King being killed. By the time the Hunxie King dispatched an envoy to negotiate with the Director of Guests, Li Xi (大行令李息),

the Xiutu King was no longer mentioned. However, it added the detail of Huo Qubing using military force to deal with the Hunxie King's tribesmen who did not want to submit to the Han.

The record in the *Book of Han: Account of the Xiongnu, Part I* (《汉书 匈奴传上》) is completely identical to the *Records of the Grand Historian: Account of the Xiongnu*, and the *Biographies of Wei Qing and Huo Qubing* (《卫青霍去病传》) is completely identical to the *Biographies of the General of Chariots and Cavalry and the General of Agile Cavalry*.

The *Biographies of Huo Guang and Jin Midi* (《霍光金日磾传》) explicitly states that the Chanyu wanted to kill both kings, hence the two kings plotted to surrender to the Han Dynasty. However, the Xiutu King regretted it; the Hunxie King killed him, annexed his tribesmen, and then surrendered to the Han Dynasty alone. It was precisely because the Xiutu King regretted and refused to surrender, thus being killed, that Jin Midi (金日磾), along with his mother and younger brother, initially entered Emperor Wu of Han's (汉武帝) court to serve in the status of official slaves (官奴).

Later, Jin Midi was highly regarded by Emperor Wu of Han. After his mother passed away, Emperor Wu issued an edict to have her portrait painted and stored in the Ganquan Palace (甘泉宫), still referring to her title as the "Yanzhi of the Xiutu King" ("休屠王阏氏"). But regardless, the Yizhixie Chanyu (伊稚斜单于) was clearly infuriated by this event. In the spring of the following year, he launched a rare, large-scale attack on the Han border during Emperor Wu's reign from the Eastern Xiongnu territories (匈奴左地) (which was the right flank from the Han Dynasty's perspective). This point is highly unusual because spring is the mating season for livestock. The Xiongnu very rarely initiated wars at this time, otherwise the damage to pastoral production would be immense; conversely, it was the Han army that was accustomed to attacking in the spring.

Next, let us return to the most frequently appearing location in this entire story: Ganquan (甘泉). There are very many records regarding this place in official historical documents (正史文献). Later generations have already collected much information when annotating and writing other works, so I will not list the sources of information one by one. When readers wish to verify, they might directly consult the *Sanfu Huangtu* (《三辅黄图》); as a geographical book, it has already compiled detailed summaries and explicitly stated the sources.

The *Chang'an Zhi* (《长安志》) quotes the *Sanfu Gushi* (《三辅故事》), stating that the Ganquan Palace is "*three hundred li away from Chang'an, yet one can gaze upon Chang'an city. It has been the location of the Circular Mound for worshipping Heaven since the Yellow Emperor / Huangdi.*" ("去长安三百里，望见长安城。黄帝以来圜丘祭天处。"). This directly pushes the religious rituals of worshipping Heaven in the Ganquan region back to the legendary era, specifically to the Yellow Emperor (黄帝), who was already universally recognized during the Han Dynasty as the ancestor of the **Hua-Xia people** (华夏族). The *Treatise on the Feng and Shan Sacrifices* (《封禅书》) also states: "*Thereafter, the Yellow Emperor received the myriad spirits at the Mingting. The Mingting is Ganquan.*" ("其后黄帝接万灵明廷。明廷者，甘泉也。").

Since the Qin Dynasty (秦代), the importance of the Ganquan region increased daily. Queen Dowager Xuan of Qin (秦国宣太后) lured and assassinated the Yiqu King (义渠王) here, and thus the Qin Dynasty completely annihilated the Yiqu (义渠). (At this time, Ganquan was already on the border between the two states under Qin's control, so the seizure of this place during the reign of

King Huiwen of Qin [秦惠文王] should be reliable). After the State of Qin (秦国) unified the realm, the Ganquan region became the starting point of the Qin Straight Road (秦直道) leading to the north. Qin Shi Huang (秦始皇) first initiated palace construction, but like the Epang Palace (阿房宫), he passed away before the project was completed. It was basically completed during the reign of the Second Emperor of Qin (秦二世), and the palace was named Linguang Palace (林光宫). After the establishment of the Han Dynasty, it inherited the palaces and imperial parks of the Qin Empire. After Emperor Wu of Han ascended the throne, he vastly expanded the scale of construction in the Ganquan region, and the Ganquan Palace, bearing the name Ganquan, ushered in its zenith era.

From the perspective of practical politics, the Ganquan Palace was the venue where the emperor spent the second longest amount of time, surpassed only by the Weiyang Palace (未央宫). It was the summer palace of the Han Dynasty and the location where many major events and significant decisions occurred. From the perspective of religious status, Ganquan occupied an extremely high position in the imperial faith of that time, because Emperor Wu of Han constructed the Circular Mound (圜丘) for worshipping Heaven here. Comparing various historical materials, this Circular Mound for worshipping Heaven should be the Tai Zhi (泰畤) for sacrificing to Taiyi (泰一). Throughout the entire Heaven-worshipping activities, Taiyi was worshipped as the principal deity (i.e., the Heavenly God).

The sacrificial activities recorded in documents were massive in scale and deeply mysterious, and they were conducted at night, lasting from nightfall until early the next morning. However, this is understandable, because Taiyi was regarded as the North Star (北极星) at that time, and it is difficult to observe during the day. In the century from Emperor Wu to Emperor Cheng (汉成帝), Ganquan was the most important religious center of the Han Empire, followed by the Shrine of Houtu (后土祠) in Fenyin of Hedong (河东汾阴). Emperor Wu of Han ordered the construction of numerous buildings related to religious rituals here and concentrated auspicious objects. Aside from the actual activities of sacrificing to the Heavenly God Taiyi (天神泰一), various minor sacrifices were also extremely frequent.

The records regarding this place in the official histories already possess quite a mystical tendency. In unofficial histories (野史) like the *Hanwu Gushi* (《汉武故事》), it would actually appear abnormal if the Ganquan Palace lacked supernatural phenomena. The Ganquan Palace occupied a very important position in the politics regarding the Xiongnu. This was not only during the period of massive counteroffensives against the Xiongnu. After the Northern and Southern Xiongnu (南北匈奴) moved toward schism, the Huhanye Chanyu's (呼韩邪单于) imperial audience with the Han Emperor (i.e., Emperor Xuan of Han [汉宣帝]) took place precisely at the Ganquan Palace. This was the first meeting between a Xiongnu Chanyu and a Han Son of Heaven (汉朝天子) since Liu Bang (刘邦) was besieged at Baideng (白登), and it was in the form of the Chanyu submitting to the Emperor.

So what about the "Golden Man" (金人)? Obviously, the appearance of the Golden Man in our nation's documentary sources is not limited solely to the Xiongnu's Golden Man for worshipping Heaven.

In the *Shuoyuan: Jingshen* (《说苑·敬慎》) authored by Liu Xiang (刘向) of the Han Dynasty (汉代), it states: "When Confucius went to Zhou and observed the Grand Temple, there was a Golden Man before the right steps. Its mouth was sealed three times, and an inscription on its back read: 'This is

a man of ancient times who was careful with his words; beware! beware! Do not speak much, for much speaking leads to much failure." ("孔子之周，观于太庙，右陛之前有金人焉，三缄其口而铭其背曰：‘古之慎言人也；戒之哉！戒之哉！无多言，多言多败’"). This passage also coined the idiom "keeping one's mouth shut tight" (三缄其口). After Qin Shi Huang (秦始皇) unified China, he confiscated all the weapons in the realm and cast them into twelve Golden Men to suppress rebellion in various regions.

What is even more fascinating is that the Xianbei (鲜卑族)—the second ethnic group to unify the Mongolian Plateau (蒙古高原) after the Xiongnu—retained the custom of "casting golden men by hand" (手铸金人) right up until they unified northern China. Naturally, this custom was not exclusive to the Xianbei; it seems to have been widely prevalent among the various *Hu* (胡族 / northern nomadic peoples) who entered the **Central Plains** (中原) since the end of the Jin Dynasty (晋末). For instance, the Yan King Murong Jun (燕王慕容儁) (*who had not yet claimed the imperial title at this time, doing so only after destroying the Ran Wei [冉魏] regime*) rebuked an envoy sent by Ran Min (冉闵), stating that Ran Min himself had attempted to cast a golden man by hand and failed, so how dare he claim the Mandate of Heaven (天命)?

Judging from the term "cast by hand," the ultimately cast bronze figures must not have been very large. Yet even so, the probability of failure remained exceptionally high, which is why it existed as a method of divination for fortune and misfortune. The northern *Hu* peoples were particularly convinced by this form of divination. During the late Northern Wei Dynasty (北魏末年), Erzhu Rong (尔朱荣) had already monopolized absolute power over the realm, yet he still dared not usurp the throne simply because he failed to cast a golden man by hand. By this time, over seven centuries had passed since the Xiongnu first unified the various tribes of the steppe.

Considering the relatively harsh environment of the steppe regions, the level of metallurgical casting for metal implements was likely not high, nor was it easily popularized. If, in the distant antiquity prior to the Xiongnu unification, a particular tribe was capable of casting (*or had acquired*) a bronze man significantly larger than a living person, gleaming under the sun, and weighing over a metric ton—(*referencing the bronze statue of the Elamite Queen [埃兰王后青铜像] currently housed in the Louvre, which was cast according to life-size proportions. According to the records of the Hanwu Gushi [《汉武故事》], the Xiongnu's Golden Man was even larger. If it were truly solid, it could weigh several tons; however, if it were a hollow standing human figure like those found at Sanxingdui [三星堆], it could not possibly be that heavy. Moreover, if readers have actually seen the large bronze standing figure of Sanxingdui online or in a museum, it is glaringly obvious from the position and posture of the bronze man's hands that it seemingly once held something, and the statue is genuinely 2.6 meters tall. Considering geographical factors, I believe the Xiongnu Golden Man should be closer to the latter*)—this would inevitably inflict a colossal psychological shock upon the various nomadic tribes of northern China.

It is completely unsurprising that such a massive bronze artifact on the **Eurasian Steppe** (欧亚大草原) during the BC era would be revered as the physical manifestation of a deity, garnering unified worship across a vast territory and serving as a political instrument to unite various tribes.

Now we have essentially acquired all the information related to this "case," and I believe the answer is already overwhelmingly apparent. Next, I will reconstruct the history of the Xiongnu Xiutu tribe (匈奴休屠部) to see if we can provide a plausible explanation that is not self-contradictory.

Considering the existence of the **Holocene Climatic Optimum** (全新世暖期), the climate in northern China during high antiquity was significantly warmer and more humid than it is today, and the distribution of primitive settlements skewed further north (*based on current population density standards*). The archaeological results of prehistoric sites have also confirmed this. The rivers in the plains were turbulent and prone to flooding, so when people chose to build settlements, they tended toward sloping terrain.

The later Ganquan Mountain (甘泉山) region (*note: this is not the Ganquan County [甘泉县] that currently falls under the administrative jurisdiction of Yan'an City*) was highly likely the religious center of a formidable tribal confederacy (部族联盟) in northern China. Across an exceedingly vast area, people universally regarded it as a sacred site for sacrifices, and this very tribal confederacy constituted the primary corpus of the subsequent **Hua-Xia people** (华夏族).

In that distant epoch, the nomadic mode of production (游牧生产方式) had not yet emerged, because horses had not yet been domesticated, and it took time for this technology to transmit into China. As the climate shifted, our nation's civilizational center began to migrate southward. The regimes established by the tribes that entered the **Central Plains** region grew powerful, occupying an increasingly dominant advantage in terms of economy and population, and became the cradle of new technologies. These political mutations altered the political status of the tribes that remained in the regions north of the **Central Plains**. Originally, they were core members of the East Asian civilizational sphere, but now they were increasingly condemned as **barbarians** (蛮夷).

However, by the Western Zhou Dynasty (西周) at the latest, these groups—referred to as Rong (戎), Di (狄), and Yi (夷) by the newly formed **Zhuxia** (诸夏 / the various Xia states) world—still shared a highly consistent technology and culture with the **Zhuxia**. During the more than two centuries of the Western Zhou's existence, the Zhou royal house consistently maintained marital alliances with the Jiang (姜) surname; among the eleven Sons of Heaven, seven had queens bearing the Jiang surname. During the Spring and Autumn period (春秋时期), it remained entirely normal for **feudal lords** to marry Rong and Di women. For instance, the mother of Duke Wen of Jin (晋文公), the hegemon with the most illustrious achievements, belonged to the Rong and Di.

The historical reality is that right up until the Warring States period (战国时期), there were indeed far too many ethnic groups and states—such as certain Jiang-surnamed regimes—that possessed this "Hua-Xia-Barbarian duality" (华夏-夷狄二象性). Even recognized barbarian states could behave in ways entirely indistinguishable from the **Zhuxia feudal lords**. For example, the State of Zhongshan (中山国) during the Spring and Autumn and Warring States periods: although other **feudal lords** frequently despised it, they certainly did not exclude the King of Zhongshan when they needed to mutually acknowledge each other as kings.

When time entered the final millennium BC, supported by universal technological advancement, the **Zhuxia** entered a period of rapid expansion, and their peripheral neighbors were heavily impacted by this mutation. On the one hand, they were violently compressed by the ferocious expansionist momentum of the **Central Plains** feudal states; on the other hand, the emergence of new technologies made a transition to a more thorough nomadic mode of production possible.

Consequently, these tribes, increasingly viewed as aliens by the **Central Plains** dynasties, began to transform into nomadic peoples. Under the military pressure of the **Central Plains** people, they migrated northward, entering the newly formed mixed agro-pastoral zones and purely pastoral regions, bringing with them technology and culture that remained similar to those of the **Central Plains**.

The Xiongnu Xiutu tribe (匈奴休屠部) was highly likely one such tribe long ago; they might have even held a lofty position within the early tribal confederacies (部族联盟) of China. During the transition of these tribal confederacies into an early state (早期国家), the Xiutu tribe still inhabited the mountainous regions in the northwest of Guanzhong (关中), maintaining their original sacrificial activities.

Because their dwelling place was exceptionally close to the **Central Plains** region (中原地区) (*Guanzhong is naturally included in the Central Plains in a broad sense*), the Xiutu people must have been exceedingly familiar with the production technologies of the **Central Plains**. Considering that technologies such as bronze smelting might have originated from the West, their exposure time to these techniques might have been even longer than that of the **Central Plains** tribes. The Xiutu tribe was, at the very least, exceptionally skilled in smelting copper, and on the eve of their northward migration, they should have already mastered relatively mature iron-smelting technology capable of manufacturing weapons.

This is not surprising at all. The Ganquan (甘泉) region is not far from the primary metal-producing areas of high-antiquity China (*e.g., Yuncheng [运城]*). From Tongchuan (铜川) northwards all the way to Baotou City (包头市) along the Yellow River, this entire region remains China's most paramount coal and metal production zone to this day, although its known excavation history is not recorded that early. They perhaps felt immense pride in their exquisite metalcrafting skills and utilized bronze human statues in their Heaven-worshipping rituals. In the final centuries prior to their northward migration, the Xiutu people might have been classified as a branch of the Quanrong (犬戎), and later, a branch of the Yiqu (义渠).

With the violent expansion of the State of Qin (秦国), the Xiutu people, along with countless other barbarian tribes (夷狄部落), were forcefully compelled to migrate north. Accompanying them on their northward journey were agricultural and handicraft technologies, political ideologies, and religious culture. By the Warring States period (战国时期), China, as a **primary classical state** (原生古典国家), had developed to a highly mature stage. These abundant civilizational achievements were infinitely precious to the steppe regions, which were dominated by the nomadic production mode (游牧生产方式). A formidable and sagacious leader would inevitably notice them and could not possibly resist the urge to exploit them.

Although it is exceedingly difficult to expect future archaeological discoveries to definitively prove this—after all, the Mongolian Plateau (蒙古高原) is far too vast, and the populace inhabiting it was far too dispersed—judging from the numerous Xiongnu (匈奴) walled settlements excavated thus far, the Xiongnu Chanyu (单于) highly likely controlled the production of critical materials by centralizing the settlement of metallurgical and handicraft artisans. He enhanced his political authority through the power of allocation (*which likely encompassed non-nomadic daily necessities*).

For the Xiutu people, the absolute bedrock for establishing themselves in their new homeland lay precisely in their metal artifacts and crafting techniques. Perhaps when they arrived on the steppe, they brought the colossal bronze human statue with them! The appearance of such a gigantic, two-meter-tall divine statue gleaming with golden light upon the boundless wilderness delivered a colossal sensory shock to the people of that era. Under appropriate guidance, this divine statue was perceived as the physical manifestation of the Heavenly God (天神).

The technological supremacy of the Xiutu people shrouded the entire tribe in a mythological aura. If neighboring steppe tribes wished to obtain certain sacrificial implements, they would naturally incline toward commissioning the Xiutu people to manufacture them and paying remuneration. Consequently, this tribe came to be viewed as possessing the capability to communicate with Heaven, Earth, and spirits. The Xiutu King (休屠王) monopolized the pathway connecting the mortal realm to the deities, and thus gradually became known as the "Jinglu Spirit" (径路神), establishing a form of religious authority.

The metal artifacts manufactured by the Xiutu tribe became highly sought after across the steppe. The finest precious swords they produced were called "Jinglu swords" (径路刀) and were presented as supremely important treasures to the Xiongnu Chanyu. During the process in which two generations of Chanyus—Touman (头曼) and Modu (冒顿)—developed the original clans and tribes into a state and unified the various northern tribes, the Xiutu tribe was identically integrated into the political structure centered around the Chanyu. From then on, they were regarded as a branch of the Xiongnu.

Because they mastered critical metalcrafting technology, the Xiutu people enjoyed an exceptionally vital position within the Xiongnu state apparatus. The worship of the giant Golden Man (金人) was aggressively weaponized by the Xiongnu Chanyu to consolidate his rule, but it remained under the custodianship of the Xiutu people. This is not surprising at all. Bronze artifacts naturally require periodic rust removal; entrusting a massive bronze artifact to people incapable of maintaining it would only result in it losing its luster.

We can vividly imagine that every May, when the Xiongnu held their grand sacrificial ceremonies at Longcheng (茏城), members of the Xiutu tribe would drive carriages to transport the Golden Man to Longcheng. This Golden Man likely played a paramount role in the Heaven-worshipping rituals. The specific rituals might have also inflicted damage upon the bronze artifact, such as smoke exposure (*note the records in the Hanwu Gushi [《汉武故事》]*)—which further reinforced the absolute necessity for the Golden Man's original custodians to execute the maintenance.

During the reign of the Laoshang Chanyu (老上单于), the Xiongnu (匈奴) thoroughly defeated the Greater Yuezhi (大月氏), forcing them to migrate westward. The Hexi Corridor (河西走廊) was fundamentally brought under Xiongnu control, and the Xiutu people (休屠人) were arranged by the Chanyu to reside and graze near present-day Wuwei City (武威市), becoming one of the Xiongnu branches situated closest to the Han Dynasty (汉朝) border.

A greater probability is that, after their initial northward migration, the Xiutu tribe (休屠部) originally inhabited a relatively southern location compared to the Mongolian Plateau (蒙古高原), maintaining proximity to the Qin and Han empires (秦汉帝国). The Chanyu possessed no reason to

forcefully relocate them further north; after all, different tribes had already adapted to specific climates over protracted periods.

Unfortunately, the good times did not last. After Emperor Wu of Han (汉武帝) ascended the throne, the geopolitical trajectory of the Han-Xiongnu War violently reversed. Within a mere six months in 121 BC, Huo Qubing (霍去病) led the Han army (汉军) to smash through the Hexi Corridor twice. Tribes such as the Xiutu and Hunxie (浑邪) suffered catastrophic casualties, and the Golden Man for Worshipping Heaven (祭天金人) was captured by the Han.

Yizhixie (伊稚斜) was infuriated and humiliated, resolving to exact severe accountability upon the Hunxie King (浑邪王) and the Xiutu King (休屠王). We do not know precisely what transpired here. Perhaps the Chanyu initially only intended to execute the Hunxie King, but the Hunxie King exploited an information asymmetry to deceive the Xiutu King, making the latter believe he was equally in peril, thereby coercing the Xiutu tribe to surrender to the Han together. It is also possible that the Chanyu was indeed angry enough initially to want to kill both kings, but after issuing a certain order, he calmed down and regretted it. Since the Golden Man for Worshipping Heaven had already been seized, it would be exceedingly difficult to reacquire; to additionally lose a tribe that mastered core technologies in metal smelting and artifact manufacturing would only be disastrous for the Chanyu.

Regardless of the specifics, while the surrender was still in the planning phase, the Xiutu King realized he was not in danger of severe punishment from the Chanyu, and thus he regretted his decision. Under these circumstances, the Hunxie King had no alternative; unable to ascertain whether his surrender plot might be betrayed, he could only strike first, assassinating the Xiutu King and annexing his tribesmen.

However, during the rendezvous process with the detachment dispatched by Huo Qubing, the original members of the Xiutu tribe were unwilling to surrender to the Han and began to flee. This was perhaps because they learned they would not have been punished by the Xiongnu Chanyu anyway, and as technical artisans, they were exceptionally scarce and enjoyed elevated status within the Xiongnu regime. From Huo Qubing's perspective, regardless of the underlying reasons, the perilous threat of the situation spiraling out of control had already materialized, compelling him to deploy ruthless measures to halt such mass desertion.

Thus, this surrender was ultimately completed, albeit with immense friction. The wife and two sons of the Xiutu King were temporarily enslaved as official slaves (官奴). Emperor Wu of Han was likely highly intrigued by the Xiutu royal family from the very beginning. He paid specific attention to the adolescent Jin Midi (金日磾) and deliberately tested him.

Upon receiving the news, the Yizhixie Chanyu was undoubtedly apoplectic with rage. Following the conclusion of the freezing winter, he immediately and irrationally mobilized his forces to retaliate against the Han in the spring. This not only catastrophically disrupted the breeding and multiplying of Xiongnu livestock, but also meant that after an entire winter, the Han Dynasty had virtually zero surplus grain left to plunder.

The underlying reason for executing such an economically irrational military decision highly likely lay in the fact that this invasion was driven by profound political motives. The defection of the Hunxie and Xiutu tribes to the Han Dynasty was not merely a zero-sum shift in land and population; it signified the commencement of the **Xiongnu Empire's** disintegration. This empire

was inherently an amalgamation of hundreds or thousands of tribes with disparate languages and bloodlines. Now, the grand illusion constructed during the reign of the Modu Chanyu (冒顿单于)—utilizing military supremacy and political-economic institutions to forge the perception that "all people who draw the bow are unified as one" (控弦之民皆一统)—was violently shattering.

Emperor Wu of Han, conversely, was overjoyed. He presumably scrutinized this colossal Golden Man (金人) for a long time, marveling at it. Perhaps this Golden Man was genuinely worshipped publicly at the Ganquan Palace (甘泉宫) for a period before ultimately being sequestered in the imperial treasury.

In that era, the Han people still retained considerable memories regarding deep antiquity. They believed that the Xiongnu, or at least the Xiongnu royal house, were indeed descendants of the Xia people (夏人). The location of the Ganquan Palace was an ancient sacrificial center for the **Hua-Xia people** (华夏族), and over an immense span of time, the Xiutu people had persistently inherited and perpetuated the sacrificial rituals (*which later centered around the Golden Man*) precisely at this location. This fact was likely no secret within the Han Dynasty, and Emperor Wu consistently weaponized this to augment national identity.

Jin Midi passed the emperor's trials. Emperor Wu concluded that he was genuinely capable of undertaking immense responsibilities, and thus bestowed upon him the surname Jin (金 / Gold), directly referencing the ancestral profession of the Xiutu people. The image of the Xiutu tribe was inevitably sanitized and elevated daily; the specific actions of the last Xiutu King himself were naturally intentionally obscured, while the "Xiutu Returning to the Han" (休屠归汉) was destined to become a romanticized historical saga, vastly overshadowing the later eastward return of the Torghut tribe (土尔扈特部东归). After all, in high antiquity, the Xiutu people might have genuinely been core members of the Yellow Emperor's (黄帝) tribal confederacy!

Capitalizing on this momentum, the Han government constructed three shrines for the Xiutu tribe in Yunyang County (云阳县). One was dedicated to commemorating the history of the entire tribe, the second was dedicated to commemorating the Golden Man for Worshipping Heaven, and the third was dedicated to commemorating the tribal leader. Accordingly, they were named: the Xiutu Shrine, the Golden Man Shrine, and the Shrine of the Jinglu Spirit (径路神祠).

The locally resettled Xiutu populace gradually assimilated with the massive influx of Han Chinese commoners relocated from the interior. Their royal family, led by the two brothers Jin Midi and Jin Lun (金伦), thrived equally well within the Han Dynasty, remaining prominent nobles right through to the Xin Mang period (新莽时期). Furthermore, they are still recognized today as the primary founding ancestors of the Jin surname.

Within the Xiongnu, the exquisite metal tools manufactured by the Xiutu people in the past continued to be utilized for a considerably long time. Among them, a precious sword even served as a witness to the Southern Xiongnu's (南匈奴) submission to the Han—a reality that one must concede possesses a profound sense of historical destiny.

Thus, through a crucial branch of the Xiongnu (匈奴), we can glimpse the underlying causes behind the rise of this empire.

Undoubtedly, the Xiongnu were a nation with phenomenally complex origins, whose identity was artificially forged. Among the Xiongnu, there were Mongoloids, Caucasoids, and the appearance of

Indo-Europeans is not considered anomalous. To which language family the Xiongnu language belonged remains unknown to this day, because this language hybridized the tongues of countless tribes; simultaneously, it is entirely normal that it was influenced by several language branches or even distinct language families. One is also fundamentally unable to ascertain whether the Xiongnu rulers were definitively descendants of the Xiahou clan (夏后氏).

However, I maintain that what can be definitively established is that the Xiongnu state was clearly subjected to decisive influence from China during its formative process. Those members of the original **Hua-Xia people** (华夏族) who diverged into nomads during the final millennium BC constituted the very absolute backbone of this state. It was precisely the technology, institutions, culture, and faith they brought that allowed the **Xiongnu Empire** to become so anomalously civilized and formidable. In other words, even if the Chanyu's (单于) paternal bloodline did not originate from the Chinese interior, almost all the primary characteristics that distinguished the Xiongnu regime from other nomadic regimes in human history originated from what later became known as the **Handi / China Proper** (汉地).

This is exactly why the Xiongnu appeared to understand the Han Dynasty (汉朝) so profoundly, and were perpetually capable of rapidly learning from their southern adversary during warfare. Throughout the entire Han period, the northward flight of sedentary agrarian inhabitants into Xiongnu-controlled territory remained a persistent problem (*naturally, not just commoners, but aristocrats and dignitaries fled north identically*). This was also identically one of the primary functions of the Great Wall (长城).

Therefore, we can articulate it this way: **The Xiongnu Empire itself was the product of the spillover of Hua-Xia civilization during its Great Expansion (大扩张) era; the Xiongnu Empire was the shadow of the Han Empire—its very own reflection.**

To modern observers, this might strongly resemble a form of elusive fatalism: a person might conquer any formidable enemy, but he can never annihilate his own shadow, unless the light itself ceases to exist.

Viewed historically, it was precisely the divergence, respective integration, and warfare between the nomadic groups and agrarian groups in northern China during the final millennium BC that forged their respective identities. The epoch-defining wars between the Han Dynasty and the Xiongnu ultimately determined which side's identity could be preserved more robustly. The Han Dynasty's victory allowed the identity of the massive ethnic group known as the "Han people" (汉人) to be unprecedentedly established. Furthermore, because of the termination of and reactionary backlash against **feudalization**, this identity did not suffer massive disruption. The Xiongnu, as the defeated party, could no longer equate their own name with all the "people who draw the bow" (控弦之民) across northern China. For this to be realized again, it would have to wait over a millennium for Genghis Khan (成吉思汗) to accomplish it.

Naturally, we must not assume that the spillover of the East Asian **Great Expansion** process merely stagnated at the formative era of the **Xiongnu Empire**. As the Han Dynasty militarily defeated the Xiongnu, certain remnants of the original **Xiongnu Empire** likely migrated westward. Today, we can observe that during the centuries following the Western Han (西汉), numerous formidable nations whose names contained the phonetic sound "*Hun*" appeared across vast regions stretching

from northern China all the way to the Danube River, and they fundamentally all projected a nomadic image.

Although scholars remain incapable of determining the specific relationships between these ethnic groups, it is highly probable that the wars between the Han Dynasty and the Xiongnu ultimately instigated the westward migration of numerous peoples across the **Eurasian Steppe**, and many were influenced by the Xiongnu to varying degrees.

This monumental historical event likely exerted a massive impact on the developmental trajectory of humanity. For instance, we observe that the initial massive influx of **barbarians** (蛮族) into the territory of the Roman Empire was precisely because they were compelled to migrate under the violent pressure of the Huns (匈奴). At that time, they were still far too primitive, and a considerable gap existed before their production level and degree of civilization could generate a fierce demand for **feudalization**; therefore, the entry of these **barbarians** appeared "premature."

Simultaneously, the degree of **feudalization** within the Western Roman Empire itself was still limited. It was immensely difficult for the local manorial lords to mount a forceful resistance analogous to that of the Han Chinese landlords in northern China or the Persian landlords (*when facing the Turkic peoples*). This proved extraordinarily conducive to the **barbarians** settling down and aggressively occupying the land, significantly reducing the probability of compromises (*where barbarians do not occupy land but are satisfied with becoming bureaucratic or military aristocrats*). Perhaps this is one of the innumerable reasons why Europe was able to march toward success in the future.

Regarding the nomadic **production mode** (生产方式), only one final problem remains. In fact, it is not even a tangible problem, but rather a conjecture whose answer is fundamentally impossible to know.

We have now observed that the eastern extremity of the **Eurasian Steppe** was excessively close to the civilizational core of East Asia (*judging from excavated prehistoric sites, a massive proportion of China's primary civilization was already situated within the mixed agro-pastoral zone*). Driven by climatic shifts, civilization here underwent a divergence. The grand steppe overlaps with a massive expanse of what is politically defined as northern China. Consequently, it was structurally impossible for the Chinese empire not to maintain exceptionally frequent interactions with its nomadic neighbors.

During the formation of the Chinese **classical state** (古典国家), this catalyzed the birth of a mirror empire in the north—namely, the **Xiongnu Empire**. However, subsequently, China's own historical trajectory derailed. It failed to enter the orbital path of **feudalization**, and instead enabled the bureaucratic state to restore itself (官僚复辟制度).

This engenders a profound question: **Did the historical reality of China independently deviating toward a restoration-bureaucratic system exert a conspicuous impact on the historical trajectory of the entire world?**

Naturally, we are not conceptualizing the type of impact where, hypothetically, China evolved into the Late Middle Ages and unleashed expansionist campaigns across every global region akin to those executed by Europe in *Our Timeline* (本位面). Rather, we are considering this question under the premise that political and military contact across various global regions was strictly limited (*i.e., prior to China reaching the early modern era*). Therefore, the impact of the mutation in China's

historical trajectory upon the outside world would primarily have been transmitted through the nomadic groups inhabiting the *Eurasian Steppe*.

On this point, my view is highly consistent with that of some Western scholars: a unified (even if not entirely unified) *restoration-bureaucratic Chinese empire* (复辟官僚制中华帝国) likely made it easier for a unified nomadic regime (游牧政权) to form at the eastern end of the *Eurasian Steppe* (欧亚大草原).

However, I wish to emphasize certain other reasons. For instance, if China had normally entered a *feudal society* (封建社会) beginning in the fourth century, the formidable *feudal lords* (封建领主) in northern China would have possessed both the capability and the willingness to restrict the activities of nomadic tribes at the eastern end of the *Eurasian Steppe* and expand their influence into the steppe.

A feudal Chinese society would inevitably generate or introduce a *feudal religion* (封建宗教). Following the expansion patterns of Catholicism, Eastern Orthodoxy, and Islam in steppe regions, the entire Mongolian Plateau (蒙古高原) should have comprehensively converted to this religion by the 10th century AD (though perhaps not every herdsman, the chieftains would certainly have believed). Facing a feudal China, the various steppe tribes would have found it difficult to generate the internal momentum for unification. They would highly likely have participated in a more complex diplomatic environment in a relatively mild manner (rather than a tributary system [朝贡体系] with a unified Chinese empire at its absolute core), appearing in China as mercenaries and partially transforming into sedentary settlers due to land remuneration brought by military service.

I believe a realistic consequence is that when China embarked on the path of bureaucratic restoration (官僚复辟), it did not merely bring upon itself a "**dynastic cycle**" (王朝周期律); it simultaneously imposed a "**dynastic cycle**" belonging to nomadic peoples upon Mongolia. Since the Xiongnu (匈奴), regimes such as the Rouran (柔然), the Turkic Khaganate (突厥), and the Uyghur Khaganate (回鹘) fundamentally lacked the capacity to establish stable regimes across vast nomadic regions. Severe natural disasters and failed wars could both precipitate the fragmentation and collapse of a khanate.

Furthermore, due to the existence of a unified Chinese empire, although the regions along the Great Wall (长城) never recovered the massive military personnel numbers of the Western Han (西汉) period, remaining in a perpetual state of military alert was inevitable. Interactions between pastoralists and agrarians in East Asia were artificially obstructed by numerous barriers for political reasons. Consequently, it was indeed highly normal for nomadic peoples to migrate westward from Mongolia. Driven by formidable leaders filtered out through a highly intense political environment, and coupled with the fact that the Chinese empire genuinely possessed advantages in certain technologies since the Han Dynasty and maintained them until recent times, this would forge a destructive force.

Therefore, generally speaking, I contend that while the Chinese empire was committing direct suicide, it concurrently dragged Iran down with it, severely devastated the Islamic world and Eastern Europe, and interfered with India. However, these nations need not rush to condemn the foolish behavior of the Chinese empire, because they were, after all, sufficiently distant. China's immediate neighbors could only be rendered even more speechless, as the Chinese *restoration-bureaucratic empire* (复辟官僚帝国) incidentally eradicated Yunnan (云南), and subsequently

delivered a stab each to Korea (朝鲜) and Vietnam (越南). (Naturally, the Chinese empire was not always capable of interfering in these regions; frequently, it was the local rulers who actively sought the "true scriptures" [真经] for ruling their populaces).

I believe the most correct action Japan took in its history was to consistently and cautiously maintain its distance from the Chinese empire from the Heian period (平安时代) through the **Chūsei (中世 / Middle Ages)**. Although this was initially done to maintain the independence of their '**Small Empire East of the Sea**' and the sacred power of the Emperor (天皇), one must now concede that this belongs to the category of "bad initial intentions that were ultimately executed well" (本意是坏的, 最后被执行好了).

One cannot forget that nomadic peoples, due to their prolonged engagement in the nomadic production mode (游牧生产方式), inevitably generated an ideological and behavioral inertia. Even if nomadic peoples conquered agricultural regions, it was exceedingly difficult for them initially to choose to become landlords and engage in agricultural management, because they genuinely knew nothing about managing land. As conquerors, nomads required a period of adaptation to alter their living habits and consciousness, perhaps taking two or three generations.

Naturally, this does not imply that nomadic peoples had no way to undergo **feudalization** (封建化); Hungary and Bulgaria serve as examples of nomadic peoples successfully establishing feudal states (封建国家). However, in a region with an unstable political environment, the longer the time dragged on, the greater the risk became. If the nomadic peoples who arrived earlier delayed their **feudalization**, how could they guarantee that no new conquerors would follow in their wake, and how could they guarantee that the remnant **classical empires** (古典帝国) would not counterattack?

For Western Europe and Japan, which achieved the greatest success in the modernization process, the peoples who "**Entered the Pass**" (入关) into the former during the **feudalization** period were not nomadic peoples, while the latter was dominated by the samurai class (武士阶级); neither had any relation to nomadic peoples. Viewed from this perspective, during the great Eurasian migrations of that era, the steppe nomads' oppression of peoples like the Goths at the western extremity, compelling them to enter Roman territory, indeed held a certain significance. Compared to nomads, it was vastly easier for the Germanic peoples to embrace a sedentary life.

Although observing the history of Our Timeline (本位面) makes it very easy to reach the conclusion that, over the long term of history, the nomadic production mode likely exerted a greater obstructive effect on human civilization. Nevertheless, I shall still offer a word of defense for the nomads here: the reason nomadic regimes exhibited such exceptionally massive destructiveness in actual history is highly correlated with the restoration of the Chinese **bureaucratic state** (官僚国家).

25, 游牧政权与封建化, 以及匈奴人为什么强大到过分

接下来让我们考虑游牧政权, 这里更多关注的不是游牧民族征服了农业生产地区所建立的政权, 而是以游牧作为主要生产方式的政权。人们可以明显看出游牧政权几乎不可能发展出封建制度, 更不要像西欧那样成熟的了。首先, 封建制度建立在对土地的控制和占有上, 土地是占首位的生产资料, 是社会权力结构的基石。对于游牧民族来说, 土地更多属于放牧牲畜的场所, 而非固定的生产资料, 他们更关注的是草场的变化, 而非具体的土地产权。其次, 游牧生产依赖季节性草场, 即使从短期来看人口也处于一种不断迁徙的状态, 长期来看, 人口的迁徙就更加显著。这种高度流动性使得建立固定的土地所有制和

复杂的社会等级制度变得十分困难。再次，封建制度最初得以形成的基石是自给自足的自然经济，以庄园为经济单位，农民依附于土地人身自由受到一定限制。而单纯的游牧生产方式几乎就做不到自给自足，肉和奶不可能满足人类所需的所有营养，所有以游牧为主要生产方式的政权都不得不跟周围的其他政权，特别是农业政权进行频繁的物资交换，无论以暴力还是非暴力的方式。最后，游牧生产方式难以建立稳定的税收体制，也不存在能够提供什么公共服务。游牧统治者顶多对于从属于自己的部落领袖定期征收一些贡品，并且提供军事保护罢了。难以建立稳定的征税体制对于组成一个复杂国家而言确实是本质的困难，强大的游牧统治者为了克服这一点往往会用分配征服战争的战利品权力来组织国家，但这显然不是一种稳定的状态。一旦遭到失败，这个政权就可能土崩瓦解，而如果赢得足够多，它就必然要向一个绝大多数人口定居的以农业生产为主的政权转变。

想要使得游牧社会封建化，我们就不得不将其置于一个极为庞大的市场中，这个市场可以使得畜牧业生产的社会剩余有效转化为货币和其他商品。并且需要一个强大的（外部）力量比较合理地分配并且限定草场，维护社会等级制度。如果我们观察中华帝国最后阶段的蒙古地区，这种变化确实一定程度上发生了。首先是明朝万历年间俺答汗与明帝国政府进行了议和，结束了明朝与蒙古之间两个世纪的敌对局面，边境市场正式开放（虽然走私酒没停过），蒙古地区随即被卷入一个庞大的市场当中。蒙古与西藏的第二次相遇使蒙古人接纳了在当时已向封建宗教发展的藏传佛教。等到清朝崛起，用武力和联姻等方式把内外蒙古都置于清朝控制中，并且推行了盟旗制度。所谓的“扎萨克”就是清代主要出现在

（外）蒙古地区的一种世袭封建领主的称呼，其封地内山河林木田产皆归其所有，不向清政府负担任何徭役和赋税。扎萨克管辖自己领地的人民并且令他们纳税，承担徭役，人身依附关系十分严格。应该看到清朝能够将蒙古变为一个封建制度主导的地区无非靠两点，第一是清朝在武力上所具有的优势使得各项政策能够强制推行，其二是清朝已经被卷入到世界市场之中。这个帝国通过东南沿海的通商口岸获得了巨额的贸易顺差，全球性的贸易网络从这里进入中国，经过国内贸易路线抵达长城沿线，山西的商人从这里北上穿过整个蒙古到达买卖城，这个著名的边贸重镇位于恰克图河以南的清朝领土，河以北的恰克图城则属于俄国。在18世纪和19世纪上半叶的清俄贸易中，清朝同样获得了大量的贸易顺差。

正是在这种已经深度介入国际市场的情况下，封建的（外）蒙古地区得以建立一种稳定的征税制度，顺治初年的《理藩院则例》中规定了扎萨克领地相当多元的征税方式，羊多的人直接上交羊，羊少的人上交米，羊特别多的人还要交毯子，有乳牛的人要交乳油和乳酒。但是游牧生产方式毕竟跟农业不同，农业地区所交的实物税不过是粮食的种子，占用的只是一个储存的空间。但是在游牧生产方式下一旦要把活的牲畜当作税收上缴，那就必须考虑领主的直辖土地能不能承载那么多牛羊了，毕竟牛羊也需要吃喝拉撒，这与封建制要求的固定土地所有相冲突。因此到清朝后期《理藩院则例》完全放弃了征收各种各样物品的要求，不管征税对象家中有多少牲畜，都按统一标准折合为米上交。考虑到外蒙古地区基本不产米，能够以米为标准征收税赋足以体现汉族商人在蒙古活动的活跃程度。但是这种封建制度对于游牧地区的确没有任何意义，他所依托的庞大的、活跃的、货币化的市场非得在近代地理大发现之后才能出现，在时间上看未免已经晚得过头，更别说还需要一个外部强力进行加强。而且从清代蒙古发展的史实来看，封建制度对于游牧地区确实不合适，例如严格限制牧民不允许越旗放牧，这何尝不是一种违背自然规律呢？清朝统治蒙古两个多世纪，整个蒙古地区都处于一种极大的衰退当中，人口减少，性病遍地，王公贵族都人人债台高筑。哪怕封建化在最初确实会带来一些衰退的迹象，但是清代蒙古发生的这些事情显然是不正常的。这也成为蒙古长期对中国表示疏远，并且产生反华思想的历史原因之一。

同样地，按理来说游牧地区也不可能经历一个古典时代，因为游牧这种生产方式就很难说如何有效改良自然环境，游牧地区的人口承载力在历史上长期徘徊在同一个水平，技术进步带来的影响远不如一点点气候变化大。然而在这里我们确实注意到了匈奴帝国这样一个异常的现象，它作为第一个统一蒙古高原

及其周边的游牧帝国，其所能动员的兵力和政治凝聚力确实有些太强了。最容易令人迷惑的是，匈奴政权的确存在一些“古典特征”，例如匈奴人在中国北方来来往往的各个游牧民族中尤其擅长筑城，截至目前考古发掘发现的匈奴城池从贝加尔湖南一直延伸到内蒙古，总共有近 30 个。从匈奴之后直到蒙古崛起，目前没有发现有哪个游牧政权在中国北方游牧地区建造过这么多城池，即使是成吉思汗统一之后的蒙古恐怕也不能与之相比。匈奴人对黄金这样的贵金属使用也比接下来的游牧民族多，不过这和真正的古典帝国区别还是很大，古典帝国的贵金属是真的作为货币在流通，但是指望游牧地区在 2200 年前就有这么发达的经济流通并不现实，匈奴人的黄金一般是用来给高等贵族陪葬的。

这个游牧政权的武备也相当好，出土兵器主要以铜、铁质地为主（也不能排除非金属兵器难以保存的原因），匈奴的砖瓦窑址和冶铁遗址也被发现了。从汉朝方面的历史记载来看，汉朝显然作为敌人非常认可匈奴武力的强大，声称匈奴兵“尽为甲骑”（以皮甲为主）并且极为擅长马上作战。匈奴政权在经济上的相对独立同样是一件非常怪异的事，因为以游牧生产方式就不可能自给自足，这个在前面已经提过了，游牧居民不得不与外界进行商品交换以维持生存。可是众所周知中国的《史记》和《汉书》里面共同记载了这样一件事，投靠匈奴的汉人中行说发现老上单于喜好汉朝通过和亲送来的丝绸和食物，就劝说单于说匈奴人对于汉朝具有军事优势的原因就在于衣食习俗与汉人不同，并且“无仰于汉”。如果匈奴人改变自己的习俗，那么汉朝人就可以轻易地收买匈奴的部众。应该扔掉汉朝人送来的礼物，以显示匈奴人自己生活方式的优越性，老上单于因此更加重视中行说。虽然汉朝和匈奴之间的边市贸易多多少少一直存在，实际上马邑之谋也就是以边贸重镇为诱饵的，然而中行说能有底气说出“无仰于汉”这样的话，匈奴人除了游牧以外其他行业的发展恐怕已经相当可观。

而且即使《史记》《汉书》中仅仅对于匈奴的官制进行了简略记载，但是我们也不难看出这样的等级制度对于一个公元前二世纪的游牧帝国确实太过复杂了。特别令人震惊的一点是，虽然匈奴帝国的政治结构依然是基于草场分配，但是却带有一种对游牧民而言非常罕见的“流官”性质。例如从左贤王这一最高爵位，同时也是管理庞大匈奴左地的官职来看，左贤王的封任几乎完全操纵于在位单于的手里，甚至单于还可以随意改变“左贤王”封号的名称。左贤王一般来说会由储君担任，但是一方面单于完全有权易储或杀掉左贤王继承次序第一者，另一方面如果新单于并非左贤王，他完全可以贬斥左贤王之子，让自己的兄弟或者儿子去担任新的左贤王。要知道左贤王即使放在当时的世界范围来看都是很有权势的人物，在其鼎盛时期可以调动七八万骑兵，即使屡次遭到重创之后也能提供三万的参战骑兵。至少从我国记载来看，匈奴王室通过对于高等贵族的任命牢牢掌握了各处封地的管理权和军事指挥权。这对于游牧民族来说是非常惊人的，即使到成吉思汗统一蒙古之后，所谓兀鲁思，即蒙古语的人民和封地，也是由被分封的诸王世袭的，大汗不可能做到像当年单于一样的剥夺爵位和封地的专制权力。事实上，人们很容易观察到匈奴帝国的这种官制已经与早期古典帝国非常相似，例如印度的孔雀王朝就采取这种行省由皇子出镇的制度（孔雀王朝的行省非常少，目前看来大概四个到六个），关键省的长官可能同时具有继承人的身份。若是站在中华帝国的角度当然可以嘲笑这种官僚制度的原始和简陋，但这对于一个以游牧为主要生产方式的政权就相当不可思议了。

一个特别容易被忽视的关键点是，匈奴人在宗教上与同期的汉朝人相当相似，而且匈奴人非常会利用宗教。匈奴帝国的宗教中心是“茏城”，这是匈奴例行一年中三次聚会中五月份最大的一次聚会的地点，各部落聚集到此祭祀先祖、天地和鬼神。（正月时各部酋长来到单于庭开小会，或许涉及制定新的一年规划以及冬季的救济问题。秋天人畜繁衍时再开一次大规模的聚会，环绕林木举行祭典，统计部落人口和牲畜数量。）这件事情单独在《史记》中出现并没有什么问题，但是只要放眼整个中国古代的文献记载就会觉得完全难以理解。匈奴单于作为一个游牧帝国的最高统治者，居然定期能够每年召集其主要下属三次。茏城作为匈奴帝国的宗教中心所发挥的凝聚力和召集作用，自匈奴被汉朝击败之后 1300 多年里

再没有于任何一个游牧政权上出现过，直到蒙古人兴建哈拉和林为止。而这种持续了近一个世纪的定期和如此高频率朝觐和会盟性质的活动，自匈奴以后就再没出现过。即使到了清朝全面统治蒙古的年代，内扎萨克也只需要三年朝觐一次清朝的博格达汗，各盟的会盟活动在最初也是一年一次，后来则更加放宽。

与这种强势到过分的统治权力相对应的是，单于本人在社会意识中被赋予的地位也具有一定神性，他“朝拜日，夕拜月”，称自己为“天所立”，最近在蒙古出土的匈奴瓦当也写有“天子单于”四字，这种意识形态显然跟中原的所谓“天子”高度一致，而且匈奴人在与汉朝外交时特别强调这一点以对应。匈奴人非常重视坟墓，从考古发现来看讲究厚葬，陵墓的规模相对于一个游牧政权而言非常大，现如今发掘的最大的匈奴墓葬与秦公一号大墓几乎一样大，这种对丧葬的态度跟当时的中国也是一致的。匈奴人和汉朝人一样相信人死后有灵（并不分敌我阵营），并且可以降下吉凶，有必要对恶灵进行安抚，例如汉将李广利被匈奴单于杀害之后因为一系列自然灾害就被视为恶灵，匈奴人感到害怕于是祭祀李广利的亡灵予以安抚。汉朝官方祭祀的一个有名的亡灵名叫“秦中”，秦中就是秦二世皇帝胡亥，同样是为了避免亡灵作祟。匈奴人也有农业生产，甚至已经出土了大量铁质农具，从形制上跟汉朝也没有区别。当然，从炼铁遗址来看匈奴人的炼铁技术已经跟秦汉时期的中原有了区别，但这很有可能是两极分化之后中原地区的冶铁技术又有所发展导致的，毕竟从战国后期到东汉中期中国的冶铁技术确实经历了爆炸式的增长。

我的观点是，游牧地区本身当然不会经历一个古典帝国阶段，匈奴种种难以理解的特征，之所以会在当时出现，这是因为匈奴帝国本身就是华夏族“大扩张”进程在欧亚大草原东端发生明显外溢所造就的。在这里我用一个我国文献中记载比较多的，同时具有非常典型性的例子来说明这一点，也就是元狩二年（前 121 年）霍去病第一次大举出击河西时缴获匈奴休屠部祭天金人这件事。在这里，只要文献中没有出现明显矛盾之处，我们就先默认它是对的。

按照从文献中出现的时间顺序，匈奴祭天金人首先出现在《史记 匈奴列传》中述霍去病首次击破河西缴获此物时。《史记集解》和《史记正义》两方给出了高度一致的注解，那就是匈奴人祭天的地方原本在云阳县西北的甘泉山下（现在咸阳市淳化县，距离西安市区直线距离 100 公里），后来秦国夺占了这里（从秦攻灭义渠的过程来看，或许是秦惠文王时占领），后来祭祀的地点迁到了“休屠右地”（应当就是指休屠部的领地，右地是指相对于单于庭的位置坐北朝南的视角），因此休屠王就保有这个祭天金人，这个金人就应该象征着天神的形象。但是这里《史记索隐》引《史记音义》声称原先匈奴（当然那个时候还不统一称匈奴）在甘泉山祭天的时候就已经在用金人了，但表示并不赞同这一说法，认为是汉朝夺取金人之后才放到甘泉祭祀。

面对匈奴人重要的祭祀道具和信仰象征，作为死敌的汉朝人却表现出了相当的热情和尊重。有关汉武帝最重要的一本野史《汉武故事》中说：“获天祭金人，上以为大神，列于甘泉宫。人率长丈余，不祭祀，但烧香礼拜。天祭长八尺，擎日月，祭以牛。上令依其方俗礼之，方士皆以为夷狄鬼神，不宜在中，因乃止。”这里多出了非常多的细节，表明“祭天金人”并非一个物体，“金人”是一个大概高两米半的金属人像，“天祭”是一个长两米左右的未知物体。从祭祀的方式来看，显然金人更为本质；从两者大小对比以及“天祭”托举日月的作用来看，“天祭”似乎是金人所代表的天神维持世界运行所用的工具。在更晚的时候魏收在《魏书 释老志》中做出了类似的叙述（可能就源于《汉武故事》），但是声称这里的金人乃是佛像，并且隐去了关于“天祭”的内容。这种选取显然有目的，公元前 121 年时佛教造像艺术本身发展才刚起步，更别说金属浇筑的佛像能够出现在匈奴人手里了，魏收为了让人们相信金人真是佛像就必须把不知道是什么东西的“天祭”给剔出去，否则人们立刻就知道那不是佛像。

有意思的是，虽然休屠王和浑邪王相约归汉途中被后者所杀，但是休屠王的长子金日磾在后来却被汉武帝极为看重，他被一路提拔为光禄大夫，并且被指定为霍光的副手辅佐年幼的汉昭帝刘弗陵。在《汉书 霍光金日磾传》传的最后“赞曰”部分，作者班固写道：本以休屠作金人为祭天主，故因赐姓金氏云。这里的记载非常关键，他不仅提到为什么金日磾会被赐以金姓，更明确指出匈奴休屠部具有制作金人的能力。而金日磾本人能够被汉武帝器重自然有其忠心能干的一面，然而作为异族王子却能做到托孤大臣这个地位，我们并不能排除这与期休屠王子的出身有关。当然聪明的读者显然也会发现杀牛祭祀“天祭”这件事情，从我国历史上来看，无论是对于定居的中原民族还是对于北方游牧民族来说在祭祀时杀牛杀马确实同时存在。但相对而言对于游牧民族而言马要更重要一些，对于中原人来说杀牛的情况更多，并且随着时间推移中原地区越来越不讲究杀马了。这里或许就已经暗示了休屠部的来源，但是因为我们并不知道汉武帝究竟是按匈奴原先的祭祀方法祭祀还是自己换了一套方法，并且《汉武故事》毕竟不属于正史，也就不再讨论了。

更加匪夷所思的是，休屠王作为投降汉朝中途反悔被杀的匈奴大酋长，居然在有汉一代享有祭祀。《汉书》在两个地方分别记载了这个信息，首先是《郊祀志下》，其次是《地理志上》。《郊祀志下》写到汉宣帝统治时期京师附近县的重要祭祀地点时说“云阳有径路神祠，祭休屠王也”，表明这里当时存在祭祀活动，颜师古作注表示这个径路神原本是匈奴祭祀的神。《地理志上》写到左冯翊地区时最后提到了云阳县，称其“有休屠、金人及径路神祠三所，越巫〈卯古〉〈襄阝〉祠三所。”（〈〉表示括号内原先应该是一个字，但是因为汉字库不收录这些古字打不出来）。忽视掉那三个南方越人的神祠，王先谦（是《汉书补注》的作者）在这里注释说所谓“径路”是休屠王的名字，死之后成为神，过去匈奴祭祀，现在汉朝将其延续下来。并非祭祀一种叫作“径路刀”的宝刀，这种宝刀是径路神留下的因此得名。如果我们现在查找这个“径路刀”就会发现它出现在一个非常重要的地方，《汉书 匈奴传下》记载汉元帝时汉朝官员韩昌和张猛与呼韩邪单于立下盟约，“昌、猛与单于及大臣俱登匈奴诺水东山，刑白马，单于以径路刀金留犁挠酒，以老上单于所破月氏王头为饮器者共饮血盟”。在这里单于为了显示对于与汉朝盟约的重视把匈奴王族祖传的宝贝翻了出来，拿径利刀在饭匕上刻下文字（大概是宣誓永不背盟的那种），把饭匕放到盛酒器中搅一搅，然后把酒倒在月氏王的头盖骨做成的酒碗里喝下去（按照颜师古引东汉应劭所言）。虽然这样离奇的仪式可能在今天人看来十分搞笑，但是在当时应该的确是单于能够拿出的最高礼节。汉朝方面对此的反应非常有趣，汉朝大臣听说这件事之后一致认为“结盟可以，但是赌咒太狠，结盟的仪式太过郑重，汉朝毫无回转的余地。应当再次祭告上天解除这个盟约，并且惩罚两个使者”。在当时，汉朝已经绝不认为匈奴还能够作为一个与自己对等的对手，并不希望与其立下太过措辞严厉的盟誓。

还有一件耐人寻味的事情就是元狩二年秋天在霍去病两次对河西地区的匈奴人造成重大打击之后当年秋天的浑邪王和休屠王归降事件，关于此事正史中五处记载并非一致。《史记 匈奴列传》中表示单于对浑邪、休屠两王在半年里被汉军两次大败，想要召回并杀掉他们，并没有指明要杀谁，从语义上看应该是两王皆杀。这两个匈奴王感到恐惧，谋划投降汉朝，霍去病前去迎接。浑邪王杀了休屠王，吞并了后者的部众然后投降汉朝了，但是没有说明为什么杀。《卫将军骠骑列传》指明单于想杀的是浑邪王，并没有想杀休屠王。完全没有记载休屠王被杀事，浑邪王派遣使臣与大行令李息接洽时就已经没有休屠王的事了，但是增加了霍去病用武力处理浑邪王不想归汉的部众的细节。《汉书 匈奴传上》与《史记 匈奴列传》记载完全一致，《卫青霍去病传》与《卫将军骠骑列传》完全一致。《霍光金日磾传》明确表明单于想把两个王都杀掉，因此两王谋划投降汉朝。但是休屠王后悔了，浑邪王杀掉了他，吞并了他的部众，然后独自投降汉朝。也正是因为休屠王因为后悔不想投降被杀，金日磾以及他的母亲弟弟最早是以官奴的身份进入汉武帝的宫廷中服务的。后来金日磾得到汉武帝重视，他的母亲去世之后汉武帝下诏将他的形象画下来存于甘泉宫，仍称其身份为“休屠王阏氏”。但是无论如何伊稚斜单于显然对此事感到暴怒，

他随即在第二年春天从匈奴左地（对汉朝而言是右翼）发动了汉武帝时期汉朝边境遭到的少见的大规模袭击。这一点极不寻常，因为春天是牲畜交配的季节，匈奴人极少在这个时候主动开战，否则对畜牧业生产破坏很大，反倒是汉军习惯于在春季进攻。

然后让我们回到整个故事中出现最频繁的地点，甘泉，正史文献中关于这个地方的记载非常多，后人在注释以及写其他作品时已经收集了很多信息，因此我就不一一列举信息的来源。读者想要查证的时候不妨直接找《三辅黄图》，它作为地理书籍已经进行了详细的汇总并且写明出处。《长安志》引了《三辅故事》，称甘泉宫“去长安三百里，望见长安城。黄帝以来圜丘祭天处。”这样就直接把在甘泉地区祭祀上天的宗教仪式向前推到了传说时代，并且是汉朝时期已经公认的华夏族的祖先黄帝。《封禅书》亦有：其后黄帝接万灵明廷。明廷者，甘泉也。从秦代以来，甘泉地区的重要性日益增加。秦国宣太后在这里诱杀了义渠王，于是秦朝彻底灭掉了义渠。（此时甘泉已经在两国边境秦国控制下，因此秦惠文王时夺取此地应是可靠的）。秦国统一之后，甘泉地区成为通向北方的秦直道的起点。秦始皇最早开始了宫室建设，但是像阿房宫一样，工程没完他就去世了。秦二世在位的时候基本建完，宫殿名叫林光宫。汉朝建立后继承了秦帝国的宫室林苑，汉武帝继位之后在甘泉地区大大扩张了建筑规模，甘泉宫以甘泉之名迎来了鼎盛时代。从现实政治上看，甘泉宫是皇帝仅次于未央宫活动时间第二长的场所，汉朝的夏宫，许多重大事件和重大决策的发生地。从宗教的地位上看，甘泉在当时的帝国信仰中占有极高的位置，因为汉武帝在这里修建了祭天的圜丘，从各处史料对比来看，这个祭天的圜丘应当就是祭祀泰一的泰畤，在整个祭天活动中泰一是作为主神（即天神）被祭拜的。文献记载的祭祀活动规模极大且神秘，而且是夜间进行，从入夜持续到第二天清晨。但是这也可以理解，因为泰一在当年被视为北极星，而昼间是难以观测的。在武帝至成帝的一个世纪里，甘泉都是汉帝国最重要的宗教中心，其次则是河东汾阴的后土祠。汉武帝命人在这里修建了大量与宗教仪式相关的建筑并集中祥瑞之物，除了真正祭祀天神泰一的活动各种小的祭祀也十分频繁。正史关于此处的记载就已经颇具神秘主义倾向，在《汉武故事》这样的野史中，甘泉宫要是没有超自然现象反而显得不正常。甘泉宫在对匈奴政治中占据了非常重要的地位，这不仅仅是在对匈奴大规模反攻期间，在南北匈奴走向分裂之后，呼韩邪单于朝见汉朝皇帝（即汉宣帝）就是在甘泉宫，这是自刘邦在白登被困以来匈奴单于和汉朝天子第一次见面，并且是以单于对皇帝臣服的形式。

那么“金人”呢？显然金人在我国文献中出现也并非在匈奴祭天金人这一处。在汉代刘向所著的《说苑·敬慎》里就有：“孔子之周，观于太庙，右陛之前有金人焉，三缄其口而铭其背曰：‘古之慎言人也；戒之哉！戒之哉！无多言，多言多败’”这里还创造出了一个成语“三缄其口”。秦始皇统一中国之后就曾经收缴天下的兵器铸成了12个金人来削弱各处的反抗。更有意思的是在匈奴之后第二个统一蒙古高原的民族鲜卑族，直到统一中国北方之后都保留有“手铸金人”的习俗，当然有这个习俗的并非仅是鲜卑人，似乎晋末以来进入中原的胡族中普遍流行这一习俗。例如燕王慕容儁（他此时尚未称帝，就是灭掉冉魏之后才称帝的）便指责冉闵派来的使者说，冉闵本人尝试手铸金人却失败了，他怎么敢称天命在他呢？从手铸这个说法来说最后铸成的铜人应该并不大，可即使如此仍然失败的概率很高，因此才作为一种占卜吉凶的手段存在。北方胡族对于这种占卜又特别认可，北魏末年尔朱荣已经权倾天下，却仍然因为手铸金人不成而不敢篡位，此时距离匈奴初次统一草原各部已经超过了七个世纪。考虑到草原地区环境的相对恶劣，金属器具铸造的水平可能不高，而且也难以普及。如果在匈奴统一之前的遥远年代有一个部落能够铸造一个（或者得到了一个）比真人还要大得多的，在阳光之下闪闪发光的，超过一吨重的铜人（参考现藏于卢浮宫的埃兰王后青铜像，这是依照真人形象铸造的。按照《汉武故事》的记载匈奴的那个金人要更大，真是实心的话能有几吨重，但如果是三星堆那样的中空人形立像就不可能那么重了。而且读者如果在网上或者博物馆里实际见过三星堆的青铜立人像，那么显然可以根据铜人两手的位置和形态判断出它手里似乎曾经拿着什么东西，并且该铜人真的2.6米高。考虑到地理上的因素，我认为

匈奴金人应该更接近后者）这必然会对中国北方各个游牧部落带来极大的心理震撼。像这样一个巨型青铜器在公元前的欧亚大草原被视为神的具象，得到很大一片区域内的共同崇拜并且可以作为一种统一各部的政治手段就完全不奇怪了。

现在我们基本上获得了和“案件”有关的所有信息，我想答案已经呼之欲出了，接下来我来还原一下匈奴休屠部的历史，看看是否能够给出一个有利的，并非自相矛盾的解释。

考虑到全新世暖期的存在，上古时期我国北方的气候比现在更加温暖湿润，原始聚落的分布偏北（按现在的人口密度为标准），史前遗址的考古结果也确认了这一点。平原地区河水湍急易泛滥，因此人们选择建造聚落的时候会倾向于坡地。后来的甘泉山地区（注意不是现在行政上属于延安市的甘泉县）很有可能是中国北方的一个强大部族联盟的信仰中心，在一个十分广大的区域内人们都将其视为祭祀圣地，而这个部族联盟就是构成日后华夏族的主体。在那个遥远的年代，游牧这种生产方式并没有出现，因为马匹还没有被驯化，这项技术传入中国也需要时间。随着气候变化，我国的文明中心开始向南转移，进入中原地区的部族所建立的政权强大起来，在经济和人口上占据了越来越大的优势，并且成为新技术的发源地。政治上的变化改变了仍留在中原以北地区部族的政治地位，他们原本是东亚文明地区的主要成员，现在则越来越被斥为蛮夷。

不过至迟在西周时期，这些被形成的诸夏世界称为戎、狄、夷的群体仍与诸夏享有相当一致的技术和文化。在西周存在的两个多世纪里，周王室始终维持着与姜姓的联姻，11位天子中有七位的王后都为姜姓。在春秋时期诸侯迎娶戎狄女子依然正常，例如功业最为卓越的霸主晋文公，他的母亲就是属于戎狄。事实就是直到战国时期像某些姜姓政权这样具有“华夏-夷狄二象性”的族群和国家的确太多，即使是已经公认的夷狄国家完全可能又表现得跟诸夏诸侯没有什么区别。例如春秋战国时期的中山国，虽然其他诸侯对其多有鄙夷，但是需要互相称王时的确没有把中山王落下。当时间进入公元前最后一个千纪后，诸夏在普遍的技术进步支持下进入了一段快速的扩张时期，而外围的邻居们也受到了这种变化的强烈影响。一方面他们被中原诸侯国猛烈的扩张势头所挤压，另一方面新技术的出现使得转向更彻底的游牧生产方式成为可能。于是这些日益被中原王朝视为异己的部落开始向游牧民族转变，并且在中原人的军事压力下向北迁徙，进入新形成的农牧混合区和畜牧业地区，并且给当地带来与中原仍然相似的技术和文化。

匈奴休屠部很早之前应当就是这样的部落中的一个，甚至于在中国早期的部族联盟中地位很高，在部族联盟向早期国家转化的过程中，休屠部仍然生活在关中西北部的山区保持着原有的祭祀活动。因为生活的地点非常接近中原地区（广义上的中原当然包括关中），休屠人对于中原的生产技术应当十分了解，考虑到像青铜冶炼这样的技术可能是西来的，他们接触的时间甚至要比中原部族更长一些。休屠部落至少非常擅长冶炼铜，在北迁前夕应当也掌握了比较成熟的冶铁技术可以制作兵器。这并不值得奇怪，甘泉地区距离中国上古时期主要的金属产区（例如运城）并不远，从铜川向北到直到黄河边的包头市，这个地区到今天都是中国最重要的煤炭和金属产区，只不过已知的开采历史没那么早。他们或许会为自己精湛的金属器制作手艺感到十分自豪，并且将青铜人像用作祭天仪式中。在北迁前的最后几百年，休屠人可能被视为犬戎的一支，后来是义渠的一支。随着秦国的扩张休屠人和其他不计其数的夷狄部落被迫向北迁徙，随着他们一起向北的是农业与手工业技术，政治思想与宗教文化。中国作为一个原生文明发展到战国时期已经相当成熟，这些丰富的文明成果对于游牧生产方式为主体的草原地区是极其宝贵的，一个强大且智慧的领袖必然会注意到它们，而且不可能不想着去利用它们。虽然很难指望将来的考古发现能够证明这一点，毕竟蒙古高原太大而生活在高原上的人民太分散。但是从目前发掘的众多匈奴城池来看，匈奴单于很可能通过集中安置冶金工人和手工业工人的方式来控制重要物资的生产，并且通过分配的权力（可能就包含对于非游牧产出的生活必需品）增强其政治权威。

对于休屠人来说他们新的家园安身立命的根本就在于金属器及其制作手艺，或许他们到达草原的时候就是带着巨大的青铜人像来的。这样两米多高闪着金光的巨大神像出现在一望无际的原野上带给当时的人们巨大的感官冲击，在恰当的引导下，这个神像被认为是天神形象。休屠人的技术优势使整个部落蒙上了一种神话的色彩，周边的草原部落如果希望得到一些祭祀工具，就会倾向于委托休屠人进行制作并支付报酬。于是这个部落被视为有能力与天地鬼神相沟通，休屠王掌握着连接人世与神祇的道路，因此渐渐被称为“径路神”，形成了一种宗教上的权威。休屠部所制作的金属器物在草原上受到追捧，他们生产最好的宝刀被称为“径路刀”，被作为极其重要的宝物献给了匈奴单于。在头曼、冒顿两代单于将原先的氏族部落发展为国家，并且统一北方各部的过程中，休屠部也被整合到以单于为中心的政治结构中去，从此又被视为匈奴的一支。休屠人因为掌握重要的金属器制作技术在匈奴国家体系中享有十分重要的位置，对于巨型金人的崇拜被匈奴单于所利用以巩固统治，但是仍然由休屠人保管。这并不奇怪，青铜器当然是需要定期除锈的，把巨型青铜器交给不会维护的人只能令其失去光泽。我们可以想象，每年五月匈奴人在龙城所举行盛大祭祀仪式时，休屠部的成员就会驾驶马车将金人带往龙城，这个金人可能在祭天仪式中扮演了重要的角色。具体的仪式也可能对青铜器造成破坏，例如烟熏的情况（注意《汉书》所载），这也更加增强了由金人的原主人们进行维护的必要性。

在老上单于统治的时候，匈奴人彻底打败了大月氏迫使其向西迁徙，河西走廊基本为匈奴所掌控，休屠人被单于安排在现在武威市附近居住放牧，成为匈奴各部中距离汉朝边境最近的几支之一。更大的可能是，休屠部原本北迁之后相对于蒙古高原来说就生活在偏南的位置，与秦汉帝国比较接近，单于也没有理由让他们向更北的地方迁徙，毕竟不同部落已经在较长时间内适应了一定的气候。可惜好景不长，汉武帝继位之后，汉匈战争的局势发生了逆转，在公元前121年短短半年间，霍去病率汉军两次击穿了河西走廊。休屠、浑邪等部遭到了重大杀伤，祭天金人也被汉朝夺去。伊稚斜感到恼羞成怒，决定对于浑邪王和休屠王进行严厉的追责。这里我们并不知道具体发生了什么，或许单于一开始就只打算杀掉浑邪王，但是浑邪王利用了信息差欺骗休屠王使后者认为他也处于危险之中，因此迫使休屠部一起降汉。也有可能单于一开始的确气到想把两王都杀掉，但他做出某种命令之后冷静下来又反悔了。祭天金人既然已经被夺去也很难再重新获得，再失去一个在金属冶炼和金属器制造上掌握核心技术的部落对单于来说只能更糟。无论如何，在投降还处于谋划的阶段休屠王就知道了自己并没有被单于严惩的危险，于是他后悔了。浑邪王在这种情况下没有办法，他不能确定自己的投降计划是否可能被告发，于是只能先下手杀了休屠王兼并其部众。但是在与汉军派出的霍去病部进行接洽的过程中，原先的休屠部成员并不愿意投降汉朝开始逃跑。或许是因为他们知道了自己本来也不会被匈奴单于惩罚，并且作为技术工人在匈奴更为稀缺也享有更高的地位。在霍去病看来不管出于什么原因现在已经出现了局势失控的危险，他就不得不用残酷的手段制止这样的逃亡。就这样这次投降总算是磕磕绊绊地完成了。休屠王的夫人和两个儿子被暂时充为官奴，汉武帝可能一开始就对于休屠王族颇有兴趣，对于少年的金日磾给予了一定的关注，并且有意考验他。

伊稚斜单于收到消息后一定怒不可遏，在寒冷的冬天结束之后，他毫不理性地在春天立刻出兵报复汉朝，这不但耽误了匈奴的牲畜繁息，而且经过一个冬天汉朝也没有什么余粮可以抢。之所以做出如此在经济上不理智的军事决策，其原因很可能在于这次入侵是出于政治目的。浑邪、休屠两部归降汉朝不仅仅是土地和人口的此消彼长这么简单，而是意味着匈奴帝国解体的开始，这个帝国本来就是由成百上千个语言和血统不同的部落聚合而成的。现在，冒顿单于统治时期用武力优势和政治经济体制所制造的“控弦之民皆一统”的想象正在破灭。但是汉武帝乐开了花，他恐怕也曾经对着这个庞大的金人端详了许久，感到啧啧称奇，或许这个金人真的在甘泉宫被公开祭祀了一段时间，后来才被收入宝库。在那个年代汉朝人对于久远的上古时期还保有不少的记忆，他们认为匈奴人，或者至少匈奴的王室的确是夏人的后裔。甘泉宫所在的地方是上古时期华夏族的一个祭祀中心，并且休屠人在漫长的时光中，一直坚持在这里传

承着（后来以金人为核心的）祭祀仪式，这一点在汉朝恐怕不是秘密，汉武帝一直就在利用这一点增强国家认同。金日磾通过了皇帝的考验，汉武帝认为他的确可堪大用，于是以休屠人的本业之意将他赐为金姓。休屠部的形象必然日益正面，末代休屠王本人的事情当然会被有意遗忘，而休屠归汉将会成为一段美谈，远远超过了日后的土尔扈特部东归，毕竟休屠人在远古时期可能真是黄帝那个部落联盟的核心成员。汉朝政府顺势在云阳县为休屠部修建了三个神祠，其中一个是为了纪念整个部落的历史，第二个是为了纪念祭天金人，第三个则是为了纪念部落的领袖，因此分别得名为：休屠、金人和径路神祠。被就近安置的休屠部人民和从内地迁来的大量汉族百姓渐渐融合，其王室在金日磾、金伦二兄弟带领下在汉朝一样风生水起，直到新莽时期仍是显贵，并且在今天仍被视为金姓最主要的得姓始祖。在匈奴，休屠人当年所制造的精美金属工具仍然被继续使用了相当久，其中一把宝刀还成为南匈奴归汉的见证者，这不得不说是宿命。

这样一来，我们就从匈奴一个重要的分支中可以窥见这个帝国兴起的因由。毫无疑问，匈奴人是一个来源非常复杂的，被塑造出认同的民族，匈奴人中黄种人也有，白种人也有，出现印欧人也不算奇怪。匈奴语言属于什么语系至今未知，因为这种语言混合了不计其数部落的语言，同时受到几个语族甚至不同语系的影响实属正常。人们也没办法确定匈奴的统治者是不是一定就是夏后氏的后裔。但是我认为可以确定的是，匈奴国家在形成过程中显然受到了来自中国的决定性的影响，那些在公元前最后一个千纪中分化为游牧民的原华夏族成员构成了这个国家的支柱，正是他们带来的技术、制度、文化和信仰使得匈奴帝国变得极为反常的文明和强大。换句话说即使单于的父系血统并不来自中国内地，但是构成匈奴政权与人类历史上其他游牧政权相区别的主要特征几乎都来自后来的汉地。这也是为什么匈奴人看起来相当了解汉朝，并且总是能在战争中迅速向南方的敌人学习。在整个汉代，定居的农耕居民北逃入匈奴控制区一直都是一个问题（当然不只是平民，权贵一样北逃），这同样也是长城的主要功用之一。因此我们可以这样说，匈奴帝国本身就是华夏文明在大扩张时期外溢的产物，匈奴帝国就是汉帝国的影子，它自己的另一面。这在现代人看起来可能非常像某种不可捉摸的宿命论：一个人或许可以战胜任何强敌，但是他无法消灭自己的影子，除非连光明本身都不存在了。从历史上看，就是公元前最后一个千年里中国北方游牧族群和农耕族群的分化，各自整合以及战争塑造了各自的认同。汉朝和匈奴的旷世大战最终决定了哪一方的认同能够更为牢固地保存下来，汉朝的胜利使得“汉人”这一庞大族群的认同空前地建立起来了，而且因为封建化的终止和反动没有遭到太大的冲击。匈奴作为失败的一方无法再把自己的名字与中国北方的所有“控弦之民”相等同，这一点要再次实现就得等到一千多年后成吉思汗来完成了。

当然我们也不能认为东亚地区大扩张进程的外溢仅仅停留在匈奴帝国形成这个时期，随着汉朝在军事上击败匈奴，原先匈奴帝国的一些残部可能会向西迁徙。我们现在能够看到在西汉之后的几个世纪间，从中国北方一直到多瑙河许多地方都出现了名字带有“hun”这个发音的强大民族，而且基本上都是游牧的形象。虽然人们现在仍然没办法知道这些族群之间具体是什么关系，但是汉朝与匈奴的战争最终策动了欧亚大草原上的诸多民族向西迁徙大概率是事实，并且许多受到了匈奴人或多或少的的影响。这个历史上的重要事件可能对于人类的发展进程造成了不小的影响，例如我们观察到最初大批涌入罗马帝国境内的蛮族就是在匈人压迫下不得不迁入的。那个时候他们还太过原始，离其生产水平和文明程度产生封建化的强烈需求还有一定差距，因此蛮族的进入显得“过早”。同时西罗马帝国本身的封建化程度也还有限，当地庄园主很难像中国北方的汉族地主或者波斯地主（面对突厥人）的时候做出有力的抵抗，这对于蛮族的定居化并占有土地，减少妥协（指蛮族不占有土地，满足于成为官僚或军事贵族）产生的可能十分有利。或许这就是欧洲能够在日后走向成功的无数个原因之一。

关于游牧生产方式就只剩下最后一个问题，甚至它并不是一个实际存在的问题，而是一个不可能知道答案的猜想。现在我们已经看到欧亚大草原的东端过于接近东亚的文明核心区（从目前发掘的史前遗址来

看，中国的原生文明有很大一部分就已经在农牧混合带了），随着气候变迁这里的文明发生了分化。大草原与政治意义上的中国北方有大面积区域是重叠的，因此中华帝国就不可能不与游牧邻居保持十分频繁的交往。这在中国古典国家形成的时候催生了北方的一个镜像帝国，也就是匈奴帝国。但是接下来中国的历史进程自己走偏了，没有进入封建化的轨道反而使得官僚国家得以复辟。那么这就存在一个问题，中国自己走向官僚复辟制度这个历史事实是否对整个世界的历史进程产生了显著影响？当然我们不是说那种假如中国发展到中世纪晚期对全世界各个地区展开如同本位面欧洲进行的这种扩张行动的影响。而是在世界各地的政治和军事接触有限的前提下考虑这个问题（即中国到达近世前），因此中国历史进程变化对外界的影响主要就会通过由欧亚大草原上游牧族群进行传导。

在这一点上，我的看法跟西方一些学者的看法非常一致，那就是统一的（即使不是完全统一）复辟官僚制中华帝国可能会使欧亚大草原东端更容易形成统一的游牧政权。不过我更想强调的是一些别的原因，例如如果中国在四世纪开始正常进入封建社会，那么中国北方的强大封建领主既会有能力也会有意愿去限制欧亚草原东端游牧部落的活动，并向草原扩张其势力。封建的中国社会必然会产生或者引入一种封建宗教，按照天主教，东正教和伊斯兰教在草原地区的扩张模式，到公元十世纪的时候整个蒙古高原应当已经全面信仰了这种宗教（当然可能不是每个牧民都信，不过酋长们应该都信了）。草原各个部落在面临封建中国时难以产生统一的内在动力，很可能以一种相对温和的方式参与一种更为复杂的外交环境中（并非以统一中国帝国为绝对核心的朝贡体系），作为雇佣兵在中国出现并且因为兵役带来的土地报酬部分转化为定居者。

我认为一个现实的结果就是，当中国走上官僚复辟道路的时候，它不仅为自己带来了一种“王朝周期律”，同时也给蒙古带来了一种属于游牧民族的“王朝周期律”。自匈奴以后，柔然、突厥、回鹘这些政权基本不具备在广大游牧地区建立稳定政权的能力，严重的自然灾害和失败的战争都可能造成汗国的分裂瓦解。而且由于统一的中华帝国存在，长城沿线虽然再也没有恢复过西汉时期那样庞大的军事人员数量，但是一直处于一种军事戒备的状态是必然的，东亚的牧人和农人之间的交往因为政治原因被人为设置了许多障碍。这样一来游牧民族从蒙古西迁的确是非常正常的，他们已经在高度紧张的政治环境中被筛选出来的强力领袖所驱使，再加上汉以来中华帝国在某些技术上确实具有优势并且维持到了晚近的时代，这就会形成一种破坏性的力量。

因此总的来讲我认为中华帝国在直接自杀的同时，顺手也把伊朗拖下水，重创了伊斯兰世界和东欧，并且干扰了印度。不过这些国家也不需要急于谴责中华帝国的愚蠢行为，因为他们离得毕竟足够远，中国近处的邻居只能更加无语，因为中国复辟官僚帝国顺手杀掉了云南，然后给朝鲜和越南各自一刀（当然，中华帝国不总是能够干涉这些地区，很多时候是当地的统治者主动求取统治百姓的“真经”）。我认为日本历史上做得最对的事情就是它在平安时代到中世始终谨慎地与中华帝国保持距离，虽然当初也是因为要维持海东小帝国的独立性和天皇的神圣权力，但是现在人们不得不说这属于本意是坏的，最后被执行好了。

人们不会忘记游牧民族因为长期从事游牧这种生产方式必然产生了一种思想和行为上的惯性，游牧民族即使征服了农业地区，在最初也很难选择成为地主并且进行农业经营，因为他们确实对于管理土地一无所知。作为征服者的游牧民需要一段时间的适应改变其生活习惯和意识，或许需要两三代人。当然这不是说游牧民族没有办法封建化，匈牙利和保加利亚就是游牧民族成功建立封建国家的例子。但是在一片政治环境不稳定的地区，时间拖得越久风险就越大，先前到达的游牧民族迟迟不封建化，如何保证没有新的征服者尾随而来呢，如何保证残存的古典帝国不反击呢？对于在现代化过程中成就最大的西欧和日本来说，前者在封建化时期入关的民族并非游牧民族，后者则是武士阶级进行主导，都和游牧民族没有关系。从这里来看，当年欧亚民族大迁徙中草原游牧民在西端对于哥特等民族进行压迫，使其进入罗马

境内确实有一定意义，日耳曼人比起游牧民来说接纳定居生活就容易太多了。虽然人们观察本位面的历史很容易得出这样一个结论：那就是游牧生产方式从历史长期来看对人类文明造成的阻碍作用可能更大一些。但是我还是在此为游牧民辩护一句：游牧政权之所以在现实历史中显示出特别大的危害，与中国官僚国家的复辟有很大关系。